



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 1]

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE— [Col. 5]

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS —

- (a) Ministry of Defence— [Col. 72]
- (b) Ministry of Health— [Col. 82]

STATEMENT—

- (a) Population and Development in Commemoration of World Population Day, 2025— [Col. 103]
- (b) World Population Day, 2025— [Col. 107]
- (c) World Population Day, 2025— [Col. 110]
- (d) World Population Day— [Col. 115]
- (e) Emigration and Returnees— [Col. 132]

PAPER—

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the University of Ghana Medical Centre for the year 2024— [Col. 102]

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE—

Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025— [Col. 137]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 216]

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Friday, 11th July, 2025

The House met at 12.22 p.m.

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us take item numbered 5 on today's Order Paper at page 2, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have, before us, *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 10th July, 2025.

Hon Members, page 1...3—

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 2(101), the name of Col Kwadwo Damoah, the practice is that we normally indicate that he is retired, as we do for Hon Toobu Lanchene. So, Table should indicate that he is a Col Rtd.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members—Table, take note of it.

Page 5...11—

Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie, before the Majority Chief Whip.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I was on my feet for page 11. It is just a minor but important correction. The item numbered 9(d)(vi), I think the proper rendition should be Greater Accra Regional Coordinating Council. So, if “Regional” could be inserted after “Accra”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Table, take note of this.

Page 12—

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, on page 12, the item numbered 10(3), the amendment carried under clause 17 was by Prof Kingsley Nyarko. It was not by Isaac Boamah-Nyarko. If they can take note of that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Table, take note.

Page 13—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, at page 13, the amendment we carried was:

“The senior Deputy Executive Director shall act in the absence of the Executive Director”.

Because I indicated that we were dealing with just two Deputy Directors, so we cannot introduce most.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, on this note, we ask the drafters to tidy it up. That was what we did.

Page 14—

Dr Tiah Abdul Kabiru Mahama: Mr Speaker, the amendment to clause 17 was by Isaac Boamah-Nyarko, not the Prof Nyarko. The reference—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which page are you talking about?

Dr Mahama: It is in reference to the correction made by Hon Defeamekpor.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Table, take note.

Page 14...16—

Mr Defeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 26, that is clause 48 to 50, the practice is that because of the issues we encountered in *Abdulai v the Attorney-General*, we no longer capture the amendment this way. We capture it sequentially. So, clause 48—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but the *Hansard* will bear us out on that one, not *Votes and Proceedings*.

Page 17...22

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 10th July,

2025, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, we will take the item numbered 6, Business Statement.

Yes, Chairman of the Business Committee?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, you called the Chair of the Business Committee and hurriedly I saw my Deputy Majority Leader rushing to present the Business Statement. He should make the appropriate—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Why do you want to be told what you already know?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, he should make the appropriate application.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, the Chairman is out of the jurisdiction at the moment— which the Minority Chief Whip is aware of.

Mr Speaker, I will seek your permission to present the Business Statement for next week.

12.32 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, leave is hereby granted.

Hon Member, before you do that, permit me to acknowledge students from Glorious Shining Star International, led

by Emmanuel Ransford Carboo, an administrator of the school, and they are from Anyaa Sowutuom. They are 56 in number. On behalf of Parliament, I welcome you. May you have a fruitful visit. Thank you very much. You may now resume your seats.

[Pupils of Glorious Shining Star International were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you have the floor.

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

Vice Chairman of the Business Committee (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan) on behalf of the Chairman: Mr Speaker, the Committee met on Thursday, 10th July, 2025, and arranged Business of the House for the eighth week, ending Saturday, 19th July, 2025.

Mr Speaker, I ask the *Hansard* to capture the entirety of the Business Statement.

Mr Speaker, the Committee accordingly submits its Report as follows:

Arrangement of Business

(a) Formal Communications by the Speaker

Mr Speaker, you may read any available communication to the House.

(b) Question(s)

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has scheduled the following Ministers and the Governor of the Bank of Ghana to respond to Questions asked of them during the week:

	<u>No. of Question(s)</u>
i. Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs	7
ii. Minister for Sports and Recreation	3
iii. Minister for Education	8
iv. Minister for Roads and Highways	6
v. Minister for Lands and Natural Resources	2
vi. Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection	1
vii. Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources	8
viii. Governor of the Bank of Ghana	1

ix. Minister for Energy and Green Transition	6
x. Attorney-General and Minister for Justice	5
xi. Minister for Foreign Affairs	2
xii. Minister for Communication, Digital Technology & Innovations	<u>2</u>
Total Number of Questions	<u>51</u>

Mr Speaker, in all, 11 Ministers and the Governor of the Bank of Ghana (BoG) are expected to attend upon the House to respond to 51 Questions during the week. The Questions are of the following types:

- i. Urgent – **13**; ii. Oral – **38**

(c) **Statements**

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to make Statements on Government policy. You may also admit Statements by Hon Members in accordance with Order 93.

(d) **Bills, Papers and Reports**

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 159, Bills may be presented to the House for First Reading. However, those of urgent nature may be taken through the various stages in a day in accordance with Order 160.

Pursuant to Order 97, Papers may be laid during the week and reports from Committees may also be presented to the House for consideration.

(e) **Motions and Resolutions**

Mr Speaker, Motions may be debated and their consequential Resolutions, if any, taken during the week.

Referral at Committees

Mr Speaker, as you may recall, during the presentation of the Business Statement for the sixth week, the Committee informed the House of the numerous referrals pending at Committees and the need to consider and report on same. The Business Committee noted that currently, 61 referrals have been made to 16 Committees. Attached to the Business Statement is the breakdown of Committees and pending referrals before the Committees.

In view of this, the Business Committee urges all Committees to prioritise consideration of the referrals in accordance with Order 267(4).

Briefing of the House

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has scheduled the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to brief the House on Tuesday,

15th July, 2025, on the recent demolition of properties at the Sakumono Ramsar Site.

The Committee has also scheduled the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to brief the House on Thursday, 17th July, 2025, on the recent 2.5 per cent increment on electricity tariff by the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC).

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 216(2) and subject to Order 67, the Committee submits to the House the order in which the Business of the House shall be taken during the week.

Monday, 14th July, 2025

Roll Call

National Pledge

Statements

Presentation of Papers

- (a) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Office of the Head of Civil Service for the year 2024.
- (b) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the National Commission for Civic Education for the year 2024.
- (c) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Births and

Deaths Registry for the year 2024.

- (d) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Krachi East Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (e) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Jaman North District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (f) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Krachi West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (g) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Krachi Nchumuru District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (h) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Atiwa West District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tema West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (j) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Mampong Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (k) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Jasikan Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

- (l) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Juaboso District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (m) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the La Nkwantanang-Madina Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (n) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Berekum Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (o) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Food and Drug Authority for the year 2024.
- (p) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ga Central Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (q) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tano North Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

Motions

Committee Sitzings

Tuesday, 15th July, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Urgent Questions

- (a) **Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (Nsawam-Adoagyiri):** To ask the Minister for Local Government,

Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the immediate steps the Ministry is implementing to address the outcry and distress of citizens caused by the prolonged shortage of papers used for printing of biometric birth certificates as well as the recurrence of this specific challenge faced by the Births and Deaths Registry.

Questions

***163. Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (Weija-Gbawe):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to provide a detailed report on the circumstances surrounding the deaths of seven Ghanaian pilgrims during the 2025 Hajj, including the specific causes, measures implemented to ensure pilgrim safety and prevent future occurrences.

***76. Mr Alhassan Umar (Zabzugu):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the total cost of the nationwide street naming and digitalization conducted.

***110. Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (Atwima Mponua):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs when work will resume on the construction of the Youth Resource Centre at Nyinahin, the district capital.

***173. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodio):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for a comprehensive update on the status of the stalled Salaga market redevelopment project.

***174. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Ododiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the specific measures the Ministry is implementing to enhance fire safety infrastructure in major markets such as Rawlings Park, Timber Market, Makola market and Kantamanto market.

***193. Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (Ahafo Ano South West):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the actions the Ministry has taken to rectify and facilitate the immediate formal commissioning of the Mankranso Methodist ICG Block, which was completed after twelve (12) years of being abandoned.

***239. Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey (Yilo Krobo):** To ask the Minister for Sports and recreation when work on the Nkrakan AstroTurf in Yilo Krobo will resume and be completed.

***246. Mr Haruna Mohammed (Asunafo North):** To ask the Minister for Sports and Recreation the cost and source of funding for the Mim and Goaso Astroturfs.

***247. Mr Haruna Mohammed (Asunafo North):** To ask the Minister for Sports and Recreation whether the Mim AstroTurf is for the Government of Ghana or the personal project of the former Member of Parliament.

Presentation of Papers

- (a) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for the year 2024.
- (b) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ga West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (c) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Mion District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (d) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Petroleum Hub Development Corporation for the year 2024.
- (e) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Kadjebi District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (f) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ningo-Prampram District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (g) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Pru West District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (h) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Jaman South Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Right to Information Commission for the year 2024.
- (j) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ledzokuku Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (k) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tema Metropolitan Assembly for the year 2024.
- (l) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Atebubu-Amantin Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (m) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Biakoye District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (n) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Fanteakwa North District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (o) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the New Juaben North Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (p) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Yilo Krobo Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (q) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of Youth and Sports for the year 2024.

Motions

Committee Sitzings

Wednesday, 16th July, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Urgent Questions

- (a) **Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (Okaikwei Central):** To ask the Minister for Education what measures the Ministry is implementing to finance the upcoming end-of-academic-year examination in public basic schools and prevent the charging of exams fees.
- (b) **Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (Pru East):** To ask the Minister for Education, measures the Ministry has implemented to prevent examination malpractices and cancellation of examination papers, especially in BECE and WASSCE, considering the negative impact, such cancellation have had on students of my Constituency in the previous years.
- (c) **Mr Charles Forson (Tema Central):** To ask the Minister for Education the steps the Ministry is taking to curb the use of fake education credentials such as PhD among others.

Questions

***220. Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (Aha Ano South West):** To ask the Minister for Education the stance of the Ministry on the refusal of the Chairman of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) in the Ahafo Ano South West Constituency to commission a safe and prepared educational facility (Mankranso Methodist KG Block), as well as the suitable interventions being implemented to ensure that the school children are not further deprived.

***223. Mr Peter Lanchene Toobu (Wa West):** To ask the Minister for Education what plans the Ministry has to adopt and support the Wechiau TVET school, which is the only technical and vocational education and training institute in the Wa West District.

***224. Mr Robert Wisdom Cudjoe (Prestea Huni-Valley):** To ask the Minister for Education the urgent steps the Ministry is taking to address the situation in the Prestea Huni-Valley constituency, where a significant number of classrooms are being managed by community teachers who are paid by parents.

***252. Ms Mavis Kuukua Bissue (Ahanta West):** To ask the Minister for Education when the government will complete and operationalise the Takoradi Technical University campus at Aketeki in the Ahanta West Constituency which has remained abandoned for the past eight years.

***267. Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (Anyaa Sowutuom):** To ask the Minister for Education the plans of the Ministry on the abandoned 3-storey building and 18-unit classroom block situated at Israel Park in the Ga Central Municipality.

***243. Ms Mavis Kuukua Bissue (Ahanta West):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the status of the following road projects in the Ahanta West Constituency which were abandoned in 2020: (i) Sankor to Cape Three Points (ii) Aboadi to Ayem (iii) Aboadi to Butre (iv) Enyano to Egyambra and (v) Ewusiejoe to Hotopo.

***244. Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (Pru East):** To ask the Minister of Roads and Highways the immediate and long-term interventions being taken to rehabilitate and maintain the Ejura-Yeji Highway to ensure the safety of motorists and commuters.

***245. Prof. Titus Kofi Beyuo (Lambussie):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following stalled road works in Lambussie will be completed: (i) Brutu to Lambussie road and (ii) Lambussie – Billaw – Bawman road.

***256. Mr Mohammed Adams Sukparu (Sissala West):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the status of the Gwollu to Fieimuo-Hamele road construction project.

***257. Mr Mohammed Adams Sukparu (Sissala West):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the state of the road construction project from Silbelle through Jawia to Gwollu.

***258. Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (Anyaa Sowutuom):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following roads in the Anyaa Sowutuom Constituency will be completed: (i) Agape road (ii) Kwashibu Road (iii) Fanmilk road and (iv) Ablekuma Abease road.

***234. Dr Ebenezer Prince Arhin (Mfantseman):** To ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the efforts the Ministry is making to ratify the Ewoyaa Lithium Agreement.

***248. Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (Weija-Gbawe):** To ask the Minister for the Lands and Natural Resources the plan to establish an effective permit-issuance system and tracking mechanism for imported excavators to operationalise the directive of the President.

***253. Ms Patricia Appiagyei (Asokwa):** To ask the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection the number of sanitary pads distributed in all regions of Ghana under the Free Sanitary Pad Initiative launched on 24th April, 2025.

Presentation of Papers

(a) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Kintampo South District Assembly for the year 2024.

(b) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tatale-Sanguli District Assembly for the year 2024.

(c) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sunyani West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(d) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Gushegu Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(e) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Nanton District Assembly for the year 2024.

(f) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ayawaso North Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(g) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Abuakwa North Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(h) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ablekuma North Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Bosomtwe District Assembly for the year 2024.

(j) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Guan District Assembly for the year 2024.

(k) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Nsawam Adoagyiri Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(l) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ahanta West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(m) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Hohoe Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(n) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tolon District Assembly for the year 2024.

(o) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Bekwai Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(p) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Minerals Commission for the year 2024.

(q) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Office of the Administrator of Stool lands for the year 2024.

Motions

Committee Sittings

- Committee of the Whole

Thursday, 17th July, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Urgent Questions

(a) **Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (Pru East):** To ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources what plans the Ministry is implementing to ensure that Parambo-Sawaba Community is provided with safe and sustainable water in the shortest possible time.

(b) **Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (Nsawam-Adoagyiri):** To ask the Governor of the Bank of Ghana the state of affairs regarding the close to hundred (100) employees who endured distress following the termination of their employment.

Questions

***268. Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources the extent illegal mining is affecting waterbodies used as raw water intake points and what steps the Ghana Water Company is taking to ensure the production of potable water for the general public.

***108. Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (Atwima Mponua):** To ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources

when work will resume on the 27 abandoned toilet facilities located in 27 different communities within the Atwima Mponua Constituency initiated by Ghana First Company Limited.

***182. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources what concrete steps the Ministry is taking to ensure consistent access to potable water for households in Odododiodioo, particularly in old Fadama, where water shortages have persisted for over six years.

***183. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources the steps the Ministry is taking to upgrade drainage systems in Odododiodioo to mitigate perennial flooding, particularly in low-lying areas such as Agbogbloshie township.

***198. Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey (Yilo Krobo):** To ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources when work will resume and be completed on the water extension project from Huhunya - Boti - Agogo - Opesika - Nsutapong - Akpo - Akpamu in the Yilo Krobo Municipality, which has halted since January 2025.

***199. Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey (Yilo Krobo):** To ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources, the plans of the Ministry for the rebuilding of the Klo-Agogo and the Nkrakan Markets in Yilo Krobo.

***269. Mr Nana Osei-Adjei (New Juaben North):** To ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources when the relocation and repair works on existing Ghana Water Company Limited pipelines between Jumapo and Suhyen will resume and completed for the road construction to commence.

***135. Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (Keta):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what measures are being taken to address the issue of power generation capacity and efforts aimed at reducing the frequency in power outages, and how the Ministry is planning to resolve the inefficiency of the transmission and distribution networks.

***136. Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (Keta):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the total number of electricity meters procured during 2017-2024. How much it cost the state and distribution and whether they have been certified and calibrated by Ghana Standards Authority.

***146. Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo (Oforikrom):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the measures the Ministry has implemented to avert the imminent shutdown of the Karpowership power plant.

***213. Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (Ahafo Ano South West):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the current state of the China Water electrification project in the underlisted communities within the Ahafo Ano South West Constituency: (i) Kofinslakrom (ii) Asikantia (iii) Dajanso

(iv) Afreseni (v) Kramokrom (vi) Kwasimarfo (v) Asuogya (vi) Damiabra (vii) Nyamebekyere (viii) Ohiapae (ix) Sunkwa (x) Mpasaaso (xi) Nyamekyere (xii) Besease (xiii) Yaahene (xiv) Nyameahyiraso (xv) Awadua Fie.

***214. Mr Peter Lanchene Toobu (Wa West):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when the less than 40% electricity coverage of the Wa West District will be improved towards the national average, which currently stands at about 90 per cent.

***217. Mr Robert Wisdom Cudjoe (Prestea Huni-Valley):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the current state of the construction of the Astro-turf in Prestea, which was awarded by the Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) Foundation in May 2020.

Presentation of Papers

- (a) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Institute of Management and Public Administration for the year 2024.
- (b) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Investment Fund for Electronic Communications for the year 2024.
- (c) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of Communication, Pu for the year 2024.

- (d) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana-India Kofi Annan Centre of Excellence in ICT for the year 2024.
- (e) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Abuakwa South Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (f) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ayawaso Central Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (g) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Gomaa Central District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (h) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the North East Regional Co-ordinating Council for the year 2024.
- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the West Akim Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (j) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ho Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (k) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Immigration Service for the year 2024.
- (l) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Driver and Vehicle Licensing Authority for the year 2024.

- (m) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Centre for Plant Medicine Research for the year 2024.

Motions

Committee Sittings

Friday, 18th July, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Urgent Questions

- (a) **Osahen Alexander Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To ask the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice the rationale behind holding a press conference to justify the filing of a Nolle Prosequi, given that it falls within the mandate of the Ministry and does not require external justification, and to clarify whether such public explanations align with best practices.
- (b) **Osahen Alexander Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To ask the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice the legal basis for his authorisation of the arrest of Professor Ameyaw-Akumfi by the National Intelligence Bureau (NIB) on Sunday, 23rd February 2025, given that Article 88 (3) of the 1992 Constitution provides a clear mandate of the exercise of his ministerial powers.

- (c) **Osahen Alexander Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To ask the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice the basis for the administrative decision by EOCO to demand justification as a bail condition for suspects in recent times particularly appointees of the previous Government.

- (d) **Rev John Ntim Fordjour (Assin South):** To ask the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, what steps the Ministry is taking to ensure expeditious prosecution of criminal narcotic cases.

- (e) **Mr Mumuni Muhammed Nurideen (Nalerigu/Gambaga):** To ask the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice the plans of the Ministry to extradite Sedinam Tamakloe who was convicted for misappropriating funds.

- (f) **Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (Pru East):** To ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs what urgent actions the Ministry has taken to ensure safe rescue and repatriation of Ghanaian youth who have been scanned and trafficked to Cote D'Ivoire by "GNet Squad".

- (g) **Nana Asafo Adjei Ayeh (Bosome Freho):** To ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the state of Ghana's Embassy in Togo and the state of Ghanaians living in Togo in the mist of the recent political instability in Togo.

Questions

***255. Ms Patricia Appiagyei (Asokwa):** To ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations the plans implemented by the Ministry to ensure the proposed Digital Innovation Fund, with an initial capital of US\$50 million is transparently managed and equitably accessible to Ghanaian technology start-ups and youth-led business.

***254. Mr Emmanuel K. Ntekuni (Pru West):** To ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations the plans the Ministry has for the improvement of telecommunication network services in the following towns and communities in the Pru West constituency: (i) Adaraja Beposo (ii) Baya (iii) Senyase (iv) Fawoman (v) Kamanpa (vi) Bronikrom (vii) Cherambo and (viii) Ankrakuka.

Presentation of Papers

- (a) Public Interest and Accountability Committee (PIAC) on the Management and Use of Petroleum Revenues for the Period January to December, 2024.
- (b) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the State Housing Company for the year 2024.
- (c) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the TDC Ghana Limited for the year 2024.

- (d) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana School of Law for the year 2024.
- (e) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection for the year 2024.
- (f) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Northern Electricity Distribution.
- (g) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Electricity Company of Ghana for the year 2024.
- (h) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana National Gas Company for the year 2024.
- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Tourism Authority for the year 2024.
- (j) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana National Petroleum Corporation for the year 2024.
- (k) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the National Theatre of Ghana for the year 2024.

Motions

Committee Sitzings

Saturday, 19th July, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Presentation of Papers

(a) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Oti Regional Co-ordinating Council for the year 2024.

(b) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Kwahu Afram Plains North District Assembly for the year 2024.

(c) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Lambussie District Assembly for the year 2024.

(d) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Wenchi Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(e) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tarkwa Nsuaem Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(f) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Dormaa Central Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(g) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sagnarigu Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(h) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Gomaa West District Assembly for the year 2024.

(i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Airports Company Limited for the year 2024.

(j) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Korle-Klottey Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(k) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sunyani Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(l) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Oforikrom Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(m) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Dormaa East District Assembly for the year 2024.

(n) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Bono Regional Co-ordinating Council for the year 2024.

(o) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Awutu Senya East Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(p) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Asokore

Mampong Municipal Assembly
for the year 2024.

(q) Annual Statement by the Audit
Committee of the Akyemansa
District Assembly for the year
2024.

(r) Annual Statement by the Audit
Committee of the Tain District
Assembly for the year 2024.

(s) Annual Statement by the Audit
Committee of the Obuasi

Municipal Assembly for the year
2024.

(t) Annual Statement by the Audit
Committee of the Kwabre East
Municipal Assembly for the year
2024.

(u) Annual Statement by the Audit
Committee of the Banda District
Assembly for the year 2024.

Motions

Committee Sitings

LIST OF REFERRALS PENDING AT COMMITTEES

No.	COMMITTEE	REFERRALS
1.	Finance Committee (6 Referrals)	1. Annual Report on the Petroleum Funds for the 2024 Fiscal Year; 2. Annual Report on the Management of the Energy Sector Levies and Accounts for the Year 2024; 3. Annual Public Debt Management Report for the 2024 Financial Year; 4. Budget Performance Report in Respect of the Ministry of Finance for the Period January to December 2024; 5. Report of the Finance Committee on the Ghana Cocoa Board (Amendment) Bill, 2025; and 6. Ghana Deposit Protection (Amendment) Bill, 2025.
2.	Public Accounts Committee (18 Referrals)	1. Follow-up Report of the Auditor-General on the Three Performance Audits in respect of: Regulating Small-Scale Mining for a Sustainable Environment; Sustainability of Sports Stadia in Ghana; and Administration of Scholarships by the GETFund; 2. Report of the Auditor-General on the Statements of Foreign Exchange Receipts and Payments of the Bank of Ghana (BoG) for the Half-Year Ended 30th June, 2024; 3. Special Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the recoveries made from disallowed expenditure in the Auditor-General's Reports from 2020 to 2023 and payroll savings as at 31st December, 2024; 4. Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana: Public Boards, Corporations and other Statutory Institutions for the Period Ended 31st December, 2024; 5. Report of the Auditor-General on the Accounts of District Assemblies for the Financial Year ended 31st December, 2024;

No.	COMMITTEE	REFERRALS
		6. Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Availability of Fertilisers to Small Holder Farmers in Ghana; 7. Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Provision and Maintenance of Toilet Facilities in Public Schools; 8. Report of the Auditor-General on the Management and Utilisation of the District Assemblies' Common Fund (DACF) and Other Statutory Funds for the year ended 31st December, 2024; 9. Report of the Auditor-General on the Management of Petroleum Funds for the Period January to December 2024; 10. Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana – Public Universities and Colleges of Education for the Year Ended 31st December, 2024; 11. Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana - Ministries, Departments and Other Agencies for the Year Ended 31st December, 2024; 12. Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Utilisation of GNPC's Share of the Petroleum Revenue on Infrastructure Projects; 13. Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on Computerised Financial and Electronic Systems in Selected Covered Entities as at 31st December, 2024; 14. Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Procurement and Management of Medical Equipment in Teaching Hospitals; 15. Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana (Whole-of-Government Accounts) for the Year Ended 31st December, 2024;

No.	COMMITTEE	REFERRALS
		16. Report of the Auditor-General on the Consolidated Statements of Foreign Exchange Receipts and Payments of the Bank of Ghana (BoG) for the Year Ended 31 st December, 2024; and 17. Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana, Pre-University Educational Institutions for the Financial Year Ended 31 st December, 2024.
3.	Committee on Local Government and Rural Development (1 Referral)	1. Annual Report of the District Assemblies Common Fund for the year 2023.
4.	Committee on Public Administration and State Interests (4 Referrals)	1. Annual Report on the Staffing Position of the Office of the President for the Period 1 st January to 31 st December, 2024. 2. Budget Performance Report in respect of Office of the Head of the Civil Service for the Period January to December 2024. 3. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Office of the President for the year 2024. 4. Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025.
5.	Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies (3 Referrals)	1. Budget Performance Report in Respect of the Audit Service for the Period January to December 2024. 2. Budget Performance Report in Respect of the National Commission for Civic Education for the Period January to December, 2024. 3. Budget Performance Report in respect of Office of the Electoral Commission for the Period January to December 2024.
6.	Committee on Lands and Natural Resources (2 Referrals)	1. Annual Report of the Forestry Commission for the Year 2022.

No.	COMMITTEE	REFERRALS
		2. Budget Performance Report in Respect of the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources for the Period January to December 2024.
7.	Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs (3 Referrals)	1. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice for the Period January to December 2024. 2. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Office of the Special Prosecutor for the Period January to December 2024. 3. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Legal Aid Commission for the Period January to December 2024.
8.	Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs (1 Referral)	1. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture Development for the Period January to December 2024.
9.	Committee on Youth and Sports (2 Referrals)	1. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Ministry of Youth and Sports for the Period January to December 2024. 2. Report on the 13 th African Games, Accra 2023, hosted by Ghana from 3 rd - 23 rd March 2024.
10.	Committee on Works and Housing (1 Referral)	1. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Ministry of Works and Housing for the Period January to December 2024.
11.	Committee on Roads and Transportation (3 Referrals)	1. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Ministry of Transport for the Period January to December 2024. 2. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Ministry of Railway Development for the Period January to December 2024. 3. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Volta Lake Transport Company Limited for the year 2024.

No.	COMMITTEE	REFERRALS
12.	Committee on Trade, Industry and Tourism (2 Referrals)	1. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Ministry of Trade and Industry for the Period January to December 2024. 2. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry for the year 2024.
13.	Committee on Employment, Labour Relations and Pensions (1 Referral)	1. Budget Performance Report in respect of the Ministry of Employment and Labour Relations for the Period January to December 2024.
14.	Committee on Education (8 Referrals)	1. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Presbyterian College of Education, Akropong-Akuapem for the year 2024. 2. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Communication Technology University for the year 2024. 3. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Nusrat Jahan Ahmadiyya College of Education for the year 2024. 4. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Mount Mary College of Education, Somanya, for the year 2024. 5. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) for the year 2024. 6. Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of Nurses' Training College, Pantang for the year 2024. 7. University for Development Studies Bill, 2025. 8. Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025.
15.	Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare (1 Referral)	1. Social Welfare on the Social Protection Bill, 2025.

No.	COMMITTEE	REFERRALS
16.	Committee on Subsidiary Legislation (6 Referrals)	1. Environmental Protection (Refrigeration and Air Conditioning Certification) Regulations, 2025. 2. Environmental Protection (Environmental Assessment) Regulations, 2025. 3. Environmental Protection (Management of Ozone Depleting Substances, Halocarbons, Halocarbon Alternatives and their Products) Regulations, 2025. 4. Environmental Protection (Effluent) Regulations, 2025. 5. Environmental Protection (Air Quality Management) Regulations, 2025. 6. Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Business Statement has been duly presented. It is for your comments.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, even though this is not part of the Business Statement, for the past three days, you have been in a very serious Dagomba smock. I do not know whether there is some history behind it. And when you wear it, you wear it properly, except that you do not add the hat.

Mr Speaker, I do not know whether there is some—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is an indication of the fact that I was in Lamashegu and I know your house in Lamashegu.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am a very popular person in Tamale, so if you know my house, that is fine—*[Interruption]*—Why is that? Mr Speaker says he knows my house in Tamale.

Mr Speaker, I would like to ask the Vice Chairman of the Business Committee when we are expected to rise *sine die* and officially, when we are expecting the Mid-Year Budget Review. Also, if the Vice Chairman of the Business Committee could programme—I need the attention of the Vice Chairman; if he could programme the Minister for Foreign Affairs to brief this House.

Recently, the United Nations Human Rights Council voted to renew the mandate

of the independent expert to protect against violence and discrimination based on sexual orientation. Ghana abstained from this vote. If the Minister can brief the House on exactly what happened and what it is about because—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Was it not voting? So, do you give reason for voting?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, he abstained on an LGBTQ vote. Last week, two men kissed at the Independence Square and our Minister for Foreign Affairs would go for such an important event and abstain?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon First Deputy Minority Whip, how many types of voting do we have? You can either vote aye, no or abstain. So, abstinence is a form of voting.

12.42 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: So, Mr Speaker, my point here is that what is actually going on in Ghana and in our society is very bad. It is not good to the extent that last week two men were kissing at the Independence Square and the Minister for Foreign Affairs will go and abstain from such an important—Is it the case that he is in support of the Lesbians, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender Queer plus (LGBTQ+) or he is encouraging it?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Alhaji Habib, I have admonished that we should not be generating debates any time we are taking the Business Statement. I was

compelled to put something on record which I do not want to repeat. We all know what happened during the passage and after the passage of the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill. So why do we want to be repeating this matter and be provoking debates?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, my question today and suggestion to the Chairman of the Committee is to find space and programme the Minister for Foreign Affairs—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is it the Chairman that programmes or it is the Business Committee?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Since he chairs the Business Committee, he should programme the Minister for Foreign Affairs to brief the House, because the interpretation of what happened out there might not be the case but what is real is that there was an abstinence from what?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I rise in pursuance of Order 122(1)(c).

Mr Speaker, by way of information, this is a House of record. The matters that the first Deputy Minority Whip alludes to, regarding two persons that were seen kissing at the Independence Square, was totally a falsehood. It was an Artificial Intelligence (AI)-generated image posted by someone on a social media handle. So my Brother Habib has no

document predicate upon which he will demand that the Minister for Foreign Affairs be invited to speak to such matters and also to justify why we abstained from a certain vote at the UN.

As Mr Speaker rightly said, when one exercises their right to vote, there is no need to justify it. So yes, by all means, we want to bring Ministers to respond to serious matters, but no trivialities, with all due respect. So Alhaji Habib Iddrisu is totally out of order.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not know when the Majority Chief Whip assumed thinking for me. What he classifies as trivial might not be trivial to me. So that is his definition and those are his words.

Mr Speaker, this is a House of record, what evidence does he have to prove that what happened at the Independence Square is AI-generated? He does not have such evidence; —he should not show me his phone. I can also show him the picture on my phone when the two men were kissing. I can also show him the picture. So when he says it is AI-generated, allow me to make my point.

Mr Speaker, also, he cannot determine what I should say, in terms of making my point that the Minister for Foreign Affairs should appear before us, because such votes are important. When they were on this Side, they made a lot of noise about LGBTQ+. I agree we did not pass it just as Mr Speaker said but the Minister owes us that responsibility. He is not acting on his capacity as the MP but he is doing that on behalf of all of us.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude on this matter, so that we will not talk much about it — [*Expunged by orders of Mr Speaker*]

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we do not joke with everything. The Hon Member cannot assert on the Floor of this House that — It is absolutely unacceptable. It should be expunged from the records and he should apologise.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me again admonish that though we have a constitutional immunity to speak on the floor of Parliament, whatever we say on the Floor can also become a subject matter of privileges. So, we need to be guided in making certain statements on the floor of the House. I do not know the evidence available to that effect. So I will consequentially direct that — be expunged completely from the record.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Let me thank the Deputy Majority Leader who just presented the Business Statement for and on behalf of the Leader of the House.

Mr Speaker, there are few issues I wish to bring to his notice and hope that we can have some conclusion or take some good decision in this regard.

Mr Speaker, if I may refer to Order 208, with your leave I read:

“Compulsory Membership of Committees—

A Member shall be appointed to at least one Standing Committee and one Select Committee.”

Mr Speaker, on this matter, it has been back and forth and I am reliably informed that my Colleagues on the other Side in the majority have dispensed of the composition of their Committees. We have done the same. We cannot continuously stand in breach Order 208 of our own Standing Orders, and, we have had instances where Members have taken course to complain both in whispers and openly, that some belong to only one Committee. On our Side, as of the last count, we had about eight Members who belong to only one Committee. I want to plead with the Chairman of the Business Committee, to the extent that we have done the composition, let us go ahead; whether we are doing it administratively, or by taking a Motion on the Floor. We have to deal with it; this matter has been lingering for far too long and it does not speak well of us. There are many of our Colleagues who are first-time Members of Parliament who just belong to a Committee and it is not good enough. It does not speak well of us.

Mr Speaker, secondly, we had the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry come into the House to answer a number of Questions. Among some of the declarations she made was that the erstwhile NPP Administration’s policy of the One District One Factory (1D1F) has been cancelled.

Mr Speaker, it cannot just be—if it is the policy of Government that the 1D1F policy should be cancelled, it is a decision of the Executive and since this is Government policy, nobody can really question it. But the Minister owns this House, the people's representatives, a duty to give us the basis for the cancellation and most importantly what the transition measures are. If we are no longer going to be stuck to the 1D1F and there is going to be a new policy, what are the transition measures? Because there are a number of corporate entities who have signed on to this policy and it cannot just be an abrupt abolition. That would not be too good for us as a country.

12.52 p.m.

Again, my respected Majority Chief Whip, who is a lawyer—Chapter 6 of our Constitution provides for the Direct Principles of State Policy, specifically Article 35(7). Government owes the people of this country a duty as practicable as possible to continue with programmes started by the previous government. So, I wish to humbly bring this to the notice of the Deputy Majority Leader that we must find a reason to get an absolute briefing on these decisions taken by the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry.

Mr Speaker, I commend the Chairman of the Business Committee. I realise that the schedule for referrals that are outstanding have been duly attached for our guidance—Also put some pressure on the Committee Leaders that they have to work.

Again, the Minister for Local Government has been programmed to apprise us on the demolition of properties which has generated a lot of public outcry. Then we have the Minister for Energy and Green Transition, also scheduled. I commend the Chairman of the Business Committee.

However, we are also reliably informed that this coming Sunday, the 13th of July, the whole of Ghana will experience a blackout and that is not accidental; it is on plan. However justifiable or unjustifiable the reasons may be, since we have already programmed the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to come to the House, I do not think it will be injurious if we additionally programme him to speak to the people's representatives on what is giving rise to this blackout? We are sitting on Saturday. Well, it is a call; it is an appeal I am making regarding the blackout matters for him to come and allay the fears of our people.

Last week, I brought this matter to the attention of the Majority Leader that the *galamsey* operators are getting closer to the Accra-Kumasi Road. Mr Speaker, the evidence is not far-fetched. Anybody who travels between Osino and Anyinam can testify to this. It is worrying.

Mr Speaker, it is worrying and the Minister for Lands who had assured—I remember I was part of the team that vetted him—These were his words “we are going to categorise the miners to ensure a proper monitoring and evaluation”. This was one of his key—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I thought you are taking a cue from what happened last Thursday when we were taking the Business Statement and the caution that during Business Statement, we should not reduce it to a political platform. The comment should really be on the Statement as presented.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I take a cue. But Mr Speaker with respect, there is a thin line between matters captured by the Business Statement and also matters we consider as matters of public interest.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You were at the Business Committee meeting.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I was.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, did you discuss *galamsey*?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we could not have. Mr Speaker, I do not want to have this exchange with you; you know I would defer to you on any day. But we could not have exhausted all the matters at the meeting of the Business Committee; we could not. Mr Speaker this is an afterthought.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what will happen is that what you have exhausted is what they have programmed for the ensuing week. That is what you should be commenting on because it is your Committee's Statement that we are looking at.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Last night, I travelled from Anyinam through Nsawam to Accra and I had a shock. Mr Speaker, I cannot sleep; I cannot sleep. [An Hon Member: Why?]
—The extent to which the *galamsefers* are rearing their activities to the Accra-Kumasi Road, well, I want to bring it to the attention of the Chairman of the Business Committee. It is for the Business Committee to decide. If it is the case that, well, we do not find it important, that will be their decision and the people of this country are watching. I am just bringing it to your notice.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Members, if at the time of presentation of the Business Statement, we want to debate, rather than commenting on the Business Statement, I will then open the floor for the debate.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Thank you.

Maybe enough of that. Chinua Achebe, in one of his popular statements, said that “an old woman is always uneasy when dry bones are mentioned.” So, I take a cue from your rich guidance. I have taken a cue.

If I may proceed further. Mr Speaker, there is a trend emerging in this House.

Mr Samuel Atta-Mills —*rose*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will give you the floor after the Minority Chief Whip has finished.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: There is a trend emerging, and I have about 15

letters coming from various Ministers who keep writing to this House that for one reason or the other, they are unable to attend upon the House to answer Questions. Mr Speaker, we can take it on face value and say that, yes, they have submitted letters, but we must pierce the veil. Situations where, for instance, the Governor of the Bank of Ghana has been called upon to come and answer Questions, and he writes to say that he is engaged in other equally important matters, when he has two deputies sitting, that cannot be tenable. Two Deputy Governors, and you say that the Governor will not come and the two deputies will also not come and respond to Parliament? That will be dereliction of responsibility.

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Chief Whip, I will give you the floor after him.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, for instance, my good Friend, the Hon Akandoh, does not have a Deputy Minister; So, when Hon Akandoh writes and says that I am engaged, and he has been fighting—he is getting grey hair. He has been fighting Covid-19 all over the place. When Hon Akandoh writes and says that he is engaged, we can understand because he has no deputy. What about those who have deputies who can say that I am engaged in other equally important matters? Are they telling us that Parliament's business is not important? This is something that I think—I brought it to the notice of Deputy Leader that on the quiet, that we

should try and engage our Colleagues who are Ministers, especially those who have deputies, so that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so that if they cannot come, the deputies will come and Minority Chief Whip will not complain that where is the Minister and why is the deputy here instead of the minister?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I will not. Mr Speaker, it will depend on the mood of the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I understand.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: So, Mr Speaker, I will bring these matters—

For instance, when our respected Majority Chief Whip had filed for the EC boss to be here and the EC boss could not make it, the deputy was here and we all obliged him. Mr Speaker, he presented and represented the institution so well. So, I think we should take a cue from these matters.

The last one, is on our ever-popular 24-Hour Economy Policy. At the Business Committee, it came up that it is an important subject matter that the people's representative should be carried along. Deputy Leader, you agree with me?

1.02 p.m.

We want to make this suggestion strongly to him to please relate to the appropriate quarters so that possibly next

week or two, before we rise, or even before we present the Mid-Year Budget Review, we can have a presentation on the 24-Hour Economy policy for us to appreciate these ones.

The last one goes to the Majority Chief Whip. We are preparing to rise. Hon Dafeamekpor, we are preparing to rise soon. He and I have been talking; there are outstanding matters. The Speaker had cautioned that such matters should not be elucidated on the Floor; that, I will not do, but we have a language. Our backyard is demoralised and morale is low. Hon Dafeamekpor should do something. Mr Speaker, when my Colleague decides to work, he can do wonders. Except that for the past two weeks, I have not been seeing things well. Maybe I have to change my lens; I cannot see him well. Mr Speaker, he should try and put matters together so that the House will calm while we expect to receive one of our own, the exchequer, the Minister for Finance. Let us deal with these matters. MPs are demoralised.

The releases—The Minister for Defence is not too happy. Hon Akandoh is also not too happy. Let us emphasise on the releases so that the Ministers—*[Interruption]*—The Hon Member told me. The releases can come early enough, so that everybody will be happy. Mr Speaker, having said this, I thank you for the opportunity.

Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Nurideen, after your Frontbench has spoken?

Alhaji Mumuni: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity; this one is a *pro bono* opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Business Committee for the job that they have done. Mr Speaker, there is something very important. Something terrible happened two days ago and I thought the Business Committee would have found somewhere to put it in the Business Statement, so that our Minister for Defence would brief the House somewhere next week.

Mr Speaker, what happened? Three days ago, a military escort was escorting three cargo cars from Bolgatanga to Bawku. On their way, one of the cargo trucks got a fault and could not move. The military that was escorting these trucks left the cargo truck there without leaving with the people. Mr Speaker, unfortunately, after they left without going with the people in the cargo truck, thugs came out from nowhere and killed three people on the spot, injuring one and two people managed to escape.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Have you brought it to the attention of the Business Committee?

Alhaji Mumuni: Mr Speaker, it happened two days ago. I told Leadership, but I do not know why it cannot be found in the Business Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then you can take a cue. In matters of this nature, your Colleagues would come to this House with a Statement, then we would grant the floor to the Colleague to make the Statement. Then, there would be consequential directives based on the Statement. Members will have the opportunity to comment on the issue.

Alhaji Mumuni: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

The only reason I raised the statement is that the Minister for Defence is here. I still urge the Business Committee to find some way to let the Minister for Defence brief the entire House on what really happened and the circumstances that led to the military abandoning the vehicle, leading to the killing of these three innocent souls.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you have two things available for you: either you bring a Question or a Statement. Yes, Deputy Majority Leader, your response. Let him respond to this.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you, Mr Speaker. The first question I think had to do with when we will rise. Information I have is that we will be rising at the end of this month; so, July 31st. The second issue was to do with the Mid-Year Budget Review. The Mid-Year Budget Review, again, will happen on the 24th of July.

Then the Committee issues. I think on the issue of the Committee on Selection, the Rt Hon Speaker has been engaging on it, but he is out of the

jurisdiction. So, when he comes back, I am sure we will get it sorted out. On the issue of 1D1F, I think the Minister was asked a Question and he basically answered it. If they want more details, I have always said that I do not see 1D1F as a policy; it is probably a brand. The 1D1F is about industrialisation, and the method we are choosing to do the industrialisation is the 24-Hour economy, so 1D1F has no space. But if they want, we would discuss with the Minister and if they need any further briefing from what he told us here, then we will take it from there.

Yes, I am glad he brought the issue of the referrals up. We have dealt with this at the Business Committee and that is why it has made its way here. We will encourage the Committees, as he rightly said, to deal with the things that have been referred to them. Sunday, 13th July—I do not know where he is getting his information from, but I will find out and engage the Minister, if we can get him to come and tell us something.

Mr Speaker, on the *galamsey* issue, I am quite interested. Why my Friends on the other Side, all of a sudden, are tackling the issue, something that they have failed to do for the last eight years—But if the Minister has anything to say about that, we will engage him and get him here.

Well, we wanted the Minister for Foreign Affairs to come here to answer a Question on why he abstained in voting at the United Nations. I mean, I am not quite sure whether, we abstained. This is obviously clear to all of us; if our former

President had assented to the Bill, the Minister for Foreign Affairs would have had a position to do the voting. Abstaining means that we do not know where we are. I do not actually get where the Hon First Deputy Whip was coming from with some people being maimed or shot somewhere in relation to the Ministers voting in the United Nations. I do not know whether it is true. I think the Chief Whip said it never happened. But even if it did, it has nothing to do with the Business Statement we are doing here today.

On the issue of the 24-Hour Economy, I am quite glad that they are getting excited about a 24-Hour Economy; they never used to. If they want any further explanation, I am sure that the man in charge will be able to come here to give us more information. I think it was launched, the policy is clear, the documents are there. If they so wish to, they can engage and read it and see where it will benefit their constituencies, because there is surely something in there for them.

Preparation for rising. I do not know if—My Chief Whip is here. Mr Speaker, I will let the Majority Chief Whip answer the question that has to do with preparation. Thank you very much—*[Pause]*.

1.12 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Ranking Member for the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs, you have the floor.

Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku: Mr Speaker, this is a matter of urgent importance and I seek your leave to appeal to the Business Committee to programme the Minister for Food and Agriculture to attend upon this House to tell us about the preparedness of the Ministry to contain the reported outbreak of Fall armyworm.

Mr Speaker, last week, I visited some farms in the Eastern Region and I saw it for myself that some maize fields have been infested with Fall armyworm. And I think, as a matter of importance, farmers will want to know what the Ministry is doing to contain the possible outbreak of Fall armyworm infestation.

Mr Ernest Henry Norgbey: Mr Speaker, in thanking the Business Committee, I want to draw your attention to some very important matters. About three weeks ago, the House, that is the Chief Whip, summoned the Electoral Commission and the Deputy Electoral Commissioner, Dr Bossman Asare, was in this House and promised to furnish the House with procurement records that led to the award of contracts of printing ballot papers during the 2024 election. He promised to do that within one week. It is about three weeks now and that has not been done. I want to crave your indulgence to direct that the Electoral Commission present same documents to the House for further investigation and the necessary actions taken.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, you are calling on me to direct, but I

would rather advise you to invoke the Rules and let the documents be produced instead of directing. The Rules are clear as to what you should do.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I want to commend the Business Committee for their programme for next week.

Mr Speaker, I want to find out when a Member asks a Question and it was scheduled to be answered by the Minister and the Minister is unable to answer because he gives a reason for his inability to answer the Question and, for weeks, it is not reprogrammed at the Business Committee level and there is also no feedback to the Member as to why those Questions are not appearing—I have gone through our Standing Orders and I am not getting clarity as to the who is held responsible, whether it is the Business Committee—Or on what basis are Members not briefed? I am saying this to the extent that, some three weeks ago, I asked an Urgent Question which was placed in our Business Statement for the Minister for Finance to come and answer and he gave some reasons as to why he is unavailable to appear before the House to answer those Questions. But two subsequent weeks, those Questions have still not appeared and I do not know—The Minister is also—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I think for an answer to your question, you must relate with the Clerks-at-Table. Maybe, they may have a reason the Question has not been rescheduled.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, if I may—Oftentimes, practically, what happens is that the Member relates with the Whips and, as we all know, the Chief Whips are Members of the Business Committee. So, the Chief Whip would take it up and relate with the Clerks-at-Table and even to the First Deputy Speaker or the Second Deputy Speaker who normally works on these Questions. So, I guess we in Leadership would have to relate more with our Colleagues and build that relationship. So, I will relate with our Colleague and get the matter resolved.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, quite apart from that, it is the Clerk to Parliament who has been writing to the various Ministers, scheduling them to come and provide answers to Questions. So, they may know the availability of the Minister or otherwise. So, you can simply approach them that this your Question has been scheduled, but the Minister was not available to respond and inquire about when the Minister will be available to respond to your Question. Whatever explanation they have, they will equally give the explanation to you.

Hon Members, I do not think we have an issue for me to call on the Chairman of the Committee to respond to. The rest are all suggestions.

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, this is just to add my voice to the position taken by the Minority Chief Whip. Yes, as a Member, when the rescheduling is done, it is the duty of the Business Committee to let it feature in the programme for the

subsequent week. But the Hon Member also has a duty to prompt, as it were, because he has sponsored the Question. So, it must be in his interest to prompt until it is actually carried through.

Mr Speaker, my Brother said something and because this is the Floor, I need to react. Ministers writing for time to be rescheduled for them to come to respond to Questions is not a new thing. So, if he says that it is an emerging trend, it is so unfortunate. Mr Speaker, I was here for eight years and, at many times, I saw Ministers plead for rescheduling of Questions that, for instance, I had filed, which was admitted and duly served on them.

So, if he paints the picture that it is a new occurrence on our Side because we are now in government and Ministers—It is rather a good practice that the Ministers are saying we are committed, but we are constrained in appearing at this appointed time, so, please reschedule that.

Then to the other matter in respect of the Governor of the Bank of Ghana, he raised the matter and he was very insistent that the Governor himself appears. He did not indicate that any of the Deputy Governors should come and respond to the issues. He said the Governor must come and explain the termination and subsequent withdrawal—So, we were minded to get the Governor to come. The Governor said that, at the time appointed for him to appear before Parliament, he had a prior engagement, so he should be rescheduled. I think it is a good practice.

Mr Speaker, in any case, that matter has been resolved. The people who were supposedly asked to go home, which became a news item, subsequently, that order appears to have been reversed and the people are at post. So, why would the Governor come and explain to the House something that no longer exists? But the call had been made, so, at the appointed time, he may come to do so.

Mr Speaker, then finally, the issues about the fact that we need to—The welfare matters, we cannot do so openly. So, he knows that there is a proper forum for us to talk about that matter. So, when we get there, we will discuss the efforts that are being made, so that, by the time we rise, Members will not be disadvantaged.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

1.22 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompheh: Mr Speaker, I am sorry I had to come back. I am not a difficult person and my Colleague will bear me out that we work closely.

I will not do anything with an intention to derail Government business. Never will I do that. I am saying that to the extent that the Clerks-at-the-Table cannot complain and speak into the microphone; they are complaining that Questions are compounding. I said this in that context, that Questions are compounding. Within a fortnight, we have received about 13 to 15 letters. So, I am saying that when the Ministers cannot come, in instances where the Hon Ministers have a Deputy, they should

empower them to come so that we can dispense with these Questions that are compounding. This is why I said this.

Finally, I was not insisting that the Governor must come himself. No. The Governor must come and speak to the record. That is it. And if the Governor cannot come and the Deputy Governor can come, so be it. I am a nice person. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Minority Chief Whip, I will always quote you. If the Minister cannot come, the Deputy Minister can come.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We must work to advance the course of governance and we in the Minority will not obstruct Government business but we will put their feet to the fire.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I remember when you were on this Side, many a time, I came and sat by you to learn a lot. So, when you are asking certain questions, I know you would use those answers one day. So, what my Chief Whip said is that the Deputies can come, but not when the Hon Ministers are deliberately absenting themselves and sending their Deputies. So, Mr Speaker, with respect, I know when you ask such questions, you will use it against us in the future.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But who made you a spokesperson for the Minority Chief Whip? *[Laughter]*

Any concluding comments?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Yes. Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I think all the questions asked have been adequately answered. And the others, I think, is just advice and we have taken the advice on board. But, Mr Speaker, we have the Ministers here to answer Questions today. So, there is nothing like a trend of Ministers not coming to the Chamber to answer Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, the Business Statement as presented is hereby accordingly adopted.

Hon Members, the next item is the item numbered 7. But before taking the item numbered 7, permit me to acknowledge our brothers and sisters who are in our midst.

Hon Members, I have the pleasure to introduce to you Members of the Portfolio Committee on Information Communication Technology of the Parliament of Zimbabwe who are here on study visit. The objective of the visit is to gain a comprehensive understanding of Ghana's innovation hub model and how it supports start-ups and entrepreneurship.

The delegation seeks to explore the collaborative roles played by Government, academia and the private sector in fostering innovation within the ICT sector. The visit is also to afford them the opportunity to identify best practices that can be adopted to nurture innovation and technological development in Zimbabwe's ICT landscape.

Our visitors are:

Hon Moyo Vusumuzi, Chairperson and Leader of the Delegation. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Hon Mapiki Joseph, Member of Parliament [*Hear! Hear!*]

Hon Munemo Laban, Member of Parliament [*Hear! Hear!*]

Hon Makaza Faith, Member of Parliament [*Hear! Hear!*]

Hon Mavhudzi Donald, Member of Parliament [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mrs Bertha R. Bhobho, Clerk to the Committee. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mrs Betty Munowenyu, Research Officer. [*Hear! Hear!*]

The delegation is accompanied by:

Mr Amon Nyahada, Trade Counsellor and Representative of the Embassy of Zimbabwe, Ghana. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Hon Members, on behalf of the House, I welcome the delegation to Parliament of Ghana and I wish them a very fruitful deliberation. Once again, you are most welcome.

[Members of the Portfolio Committee on Information Communication Technology of the Parliament of Zimbabwe were acknowledged]

Hon Members, the item numbered 7. The Hon Ministers have been scheduled to come and respond to Questions.

The Hon Minister for Defence is here as scheduled. Hon Minister, may you take your designated seat to respond to the Questions slated for you.

Hon Members, we have the Question numbered 166 standing in the name of Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah, Member of Parliament for Old Tafo.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

Status of the Presidential Jet when the Vice President returned to Ghana with a Private Jet

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I rise to ask the Minister for Defence whether the presidential jet was unavailable, restricted or assigned other duties at the time the Vice President returned to Ghana aboard a private jet.

Minister for Defence (Dr Edward Kofi Omane Boamah): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The Presidential Jet — Falcon 900EX EASY Registration Number 9G-EXE — was unavailable on Thursday 22nd May, 2025 when the Vice President returned to Ghana. The aircraft has been undergoing a 24-Monthly/1600 Flight Hour inspection in (Le Bourget) France since 11th March, 2025.

After series of postponements of when the jet was to return to Ghana (due to risky multifocal massive defects identified and being worked on) the

inspection is expected to be completed by 31st July, 2025.

In conclusion, the Presidential Jet, Falcon 900EX EASY Registration Number 9G-EXE, was unavailable on Thursday, 22nd May, 2025 when the Vice President returned to Ghana.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

1.32 p.m.

Mr Assafuah: Rightly so, Mr Speaker. When you check paragraph 2 of the Hon Minister's Answer which says that:

“After series of postponements of when the jet was to return to Ghana (due to risky multifocal massive defects identified and being worked on) ...”

I want to ask the Minister; the nature of that multifocal massive defect? Or if he can throw more light on the categories of that defect.

Dr Boamah: Mr Speaker, I decided to keep the answer brief because I did not want to go too much into the details of the brief. But, for the benefit of this august House—There is corrosion in the air intake plug receptacle of the second engine of the aircraft. Intermittent tripping of the starter generator of the second engine. There is the need to install a new turbofan. To be more specific; the fuel tank is corroded; the

left-hand feeder tank corroded; the right-hand feeder tank corroded; the left-hand centre wing tank heavily corroded; the right-hand centre wing tank heavily corroded and the turbofan also heavily corroded.

Mr Assafuah — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I think for some time now we have decided to limit supplementary questions to one.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, for this one I will crave for your indulgence—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Except that what we have agreed upon would not work—

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, this is an important matter.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I know that for the past days we did agree to that. But, Mr Speaker, with respect, today is Friday. So, I want to appeal to you to at least give him some one extra supplementary question. We also have only four questions. So, Mr Speaker, with respect, if you can just add one more extra question for him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. I am not taking the decision. It is the agreement that the leadership of the House has reached. That is what we are implementing.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have quite some heavy businesses today. Today being Friday, that is why we

shifted the sitting from 2 p.m to 12 noon. So, we could have enough time to do them. Therefore, the limitation of supplementary to one was agreed. Let us rather give other Members who may have one supplementary to ask, so we can move to the next question.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, that is why I am appealing to my Colleague, the Majority Chief Whip, to at least allow for two supplementary.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, we are even eating into our time. You may ask the second supplementary question.

Mr Assafuah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, let me be very brief on this., I want to ask the Hon Minister, if the defects that he outlined, has anything to do with the previous administration's inability to follow the maintenance protocol? Because I remember that at a point in time, he mentioned that the private jet is now serviceable and could be used.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You have asked a question, so Hon Minister your answer.

Dr Boamah: Mr Speaker, the aircraft is almost 15 years old. If you check the various delays that it has suffered; as in when it goes for maintenance, repair, or overhaul, if they indicate that it is supposed to arrive on a particular date—In 2020, there was no delay, in 2021 there was no delay; but, between 2022 and 2023, as a result of extra work that they had to do on it, it delayed for two and a half months. In 2024 it delayed for

two months, and in 2025, coincidentally, this is the fourth month because it left 11th March, and today is 11th July. So, it has been four months now.

What I can say is, rather than situate it within the context of New Patriotic Party (NPP) and National Democratic Congress (NDC) administration, let us look at it as a corroded aircraft that requires massive works.

Initially, when the aircraft left the shores of Ghana on the 11th, the indicative date was it was to return in two weeks. Four months on, just this morning, I have received additional information that even the end of month cannot be sustained. So, we should be expecting it beyond the end of this month. What that means is that it will be going beyond four months.

Most importantly, this is an aircraft that does not just service the Executive, it services the Legislature, sometimes other arms of government, and sometimes different institutions in the country. This is the state in which it is. Some parts corroded and other parts heavily corroded. That is what we have before us. I will plead that we do not situate it within NPP and NDC discourse.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker in the answer of the Minister, he said that even the dates that he has provided on the advertised Order Paper, stating that “the inspection is expected to be completed by the 31st July, 2025”.

So, if this date is not feasible, what is the tentative date that we should be

expecting it? And within this period, is it the case that the President will be chartering a jet anytime he wants to do an international travel or what other arrangement is being done?

Dr Boamah: Mr Speaker, the information came only this morning because I wanted to check, and check again whether the 31st date that had been given was going to be sustained.

1.42 p.m.

They are unable to indicate exactly when it will be returning and all efforts are being exerted to ensure that we are able to have it in good time. So, I do not want to guess a date that would not be feasible. So, let us wait for the technical people who are working on it in France to complete all the necessary checks, heal the aircraft as much as they can. But the reality is that it is an old aircraft which has been around for 15 years now. Thank you.

On the aspect of how the President is going to be travelling, the President has travelled on some occasions with the CASA C-295. We are all aware that sometimes he travels with the CASA C-295. So, let us leave that also to the decision of the Air Force and also the Presidency to decide how the movement of the President and other Arms of Government that hitherto, would have made use of the presidential jet, will be travelling. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we may take one more

supplementary question. Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me find out from the Hon Minister for Defence, what exactly the current state of the presidential jet is. You have given snippets of this, but what exactly is the current state?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Dr Boamah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The current state of the presidential jet — If I am to summarise, it is an aircraft that is almost 15 years old, that has massive multifocal corrosion, including very important parts of the machine. This is an air asset of the Air Force that carries not just the President or the Executive, but sometimes the Legislature, other arms of government, and other institutions.

We are trying to fix these defects, but they keep on identifying new defects as they fix them. One serious aspect of the identification is that, when they realised that the turbofan was heavily corroded and it required replacement, the company did not have readily available spare. This has deeper implications. Normally, like all technologies, over time, when we do not have many of that in circulation, companies do not produce many of such spares. But after a series of negotiations, a spare was received and that has been installed successfully. No one can predict, going forward, if other spares also get dysfunctional, whether we are going to be able to have others for replacement.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we cannot set the Rules and come here and breach it, so I intend to move to the Question numbered 167, standing in the name of Hon Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni. You have the floor.

The Completion of the Forward Operation Base in Nalerigu

Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (NPP — Nalerigu/Gambaga): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Defence when the Forward Operating Base (FOB) started by the previous government in Nalerigu will be completed.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister, you have the floor.

Dr Boamah: The Forward Operating Base at Nalerigu is one of 15 Forward Operating Bases (FOBs) being constructed by the Ministry of Defence for the Ghana Armed Forces in northern Ghana. The contract for the FOBs was signed in March 2021. Work commenced in November 2021. Messrs Paramount Project Management Services is the main contractor. The FOBs are located at Tamale, Wa, Bolga, Jirapa, Tuna, Tumu, Navio, Bunkpurugu, Bazua, Hamile, Bole, Dollar Power, Bimbilla, Saboba, and Nalerigu.

Work was scheduled to be completed in December 2023. However, as of December 2024, the overall status of the

project was approximately 55 per cent. It has improved from 55 per cent to 60 per cent currently. Progress of completion and or status of individual FOBs ranges from 5 per cent (Dollar Power) to about 98 per cent (Jirapa). FOB Nalerigu currently stands at 30 per cent.

It is important to note that due to operational reasons and non-availability of funds, in April 2024, the Ministry of Defence agreed with the contractor to prioritise the completion of four FOBs, namely Bazua, Hamile, Jirapa, and Tumu.

As of December 2024, outstanding payables (payment certificates for work done but not paid) due to the contractor, stand at US\$17,198,45 1.20, less other contractual charges such as interest on delayed payment and other claims from the contractor. This has contributed to the stalled works including the Nalerigu FOB.

Interventions

Currently, Government has expedited action and ensured that verification of the payables has been completed.

Most importantly, under the 'Big Push Agenda', His Excellency John Dramani Mahama — President of the Republic and Commander-In-Chief of the Ghana Armed Forces is leading the charge for the Ministry of Defence to access funding to complete all the FOBs that were scheduled to have been completed by December 2023.

All other things being equal, all the 15 FOBs including Nalerigu's will be

completed by the second quarter of 2027.
Thank you.

Mr Frist Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Alhaji Mumuni: Mr Speaker, I do not have any supplementary questions. I just want to thank you and thank the Minister for the response.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, on this note, on your behalf, I sincerely thank the Minister for attending upon the House to respond to Questions. Hon Minister, thank you very much.

You are hereby discharged.

Hon Members, we will then move to the next set of Questions scheduled for the Minister for Health. Hon Minister, may you take your designated seat.

1.52 p.m.

Hon Members, before doing so, let me also acknowledge the presence of students of the Tertiary Education Institutions Network (TEIN) of the Accra Technical University. They are led by Tetteh Imran Dawda Miguimah, who is the president of TEIN. They are from the Klottey Korle Constituency. Is the Member of Parliament here? Can you stand and wave at them— *[The Hon Member of Klottey Korle waved at the students]*—They are 53 in number.

Hon Members, among them is my dear wife, Angel Kafui Ahiafor— *[Hear! Hear!]*

[Students of the Tertiary Education Institutions Network of the Accra Technical University were acknowledged]

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: So, Mr Speaker, at least, now, I understand your mood today—*[Laughter]*—And I think that your wife should always visit us, so that we have the best of you every day, Mr Speaker. But your wife is very beautiful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you are welcome. We then move to the Question numbered 195, which stands in the name of Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, Member of parliament for Weija-Gbawe.

Mr Addy: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 88(3); I have the authority of the Hon Member to ask the Minister for Health—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you have the leave to ask the Question.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF HEALTH

Measures to Address Concerns of 30,000 Unemployed Health Workers

Mr Fredrick Addy on behalf of Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP —Weija-Gbawe): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health the measures being implemented to address the concerns of thirty thousand (30,000) trained but unemployed health workers who are demanding posting despite critical staff

shortages in health facilities across the nation.

Minister for Health (Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh) (MP): Mr Speaker, currently, the number of health workers demanding employment is substantial and far above the 30,000 as quoted. Please, permit me to provide some details of health professionals currently eligible for employment but yet to be recruited.

Nurses

Mr Speaker, we have the 2021 batch with a total of 15,947; the 2022 batch with a total of 17,176; and the 2023 batch with a total of 15,755. This gives us a total of 48,878 unemployed nurses. I must also state that approximately 15,000 nurses were given financial clearance and employed in December 2024 and the processes of putting them on payroll are still ongoing.

Allied Health Professionals

Mr Speaker, now, there is another cadre of health professionals called allied health professionals. This group has not received any financial clearance since 2019— [**Some Members of the Majority: Eii!**]—We have a total of 21,570 of unemployed allied health professionals of various categories from 2019 to date.

Pharmacists

Mr Speaker, this group also has not received any financial clearance since 2019. We have a total of 1,621 of

unemployed pharmacists from 2019 to date.

Doctors

The Ministry has also started the process to recruit over 900 medical doctors who are currently at home.

Solutions

Mr Speaker, the problem is, therefore, enormous, but we are committed to finding a solution to it.

Financial Clearance

The Ministry is actively engaging relevant stakeholders, including the Ministry of Finance, to ensure that recruitment of professionals is done as soon as possible to beef up the numbers at the various health delivery institutions to promote quality of care for all people living in Ghana.

Managed migration

Mr Speaker, another measure being pursued by the Ministry of Health to reduce the number of unemployed health professionals is the managed migration of Ghanaian health professionals. The Ministry has received formal requests from over 13 countries expressing interest in the recruitment and deployment of qualified nurses and other health professionals from Ghana. The Ministry has put together a team to come out with a policy framework and guidelines to ensure efficiency in the recruitment process to protect the interests of our citizens and ensure that

Ghana receives the required benefits from these arrangements.

Other initiatives

Mr Speaker, the Ministry is also putting together other initiatives to help absorb more professionals who are unemployed, including engagements with the private sector on arrangements to employ more health professionals at their various institutions.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, I wish to assure the Hon Member and the good people of Ghana that the Ministry remains fully committed to ensuring our health professionals are engaged to provide quality health services to all people living in Ghana.

I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Addy: Mr Speaker, in the Response of the Minister, he said 15,000 nurses were given financial clearance. I want to find out from the Minister how many have been placed on the payroll as of now.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, approximately 8,000 of them have been placed on payroll. Others are yet to have a hologram and others are also yet to have their clearance renewed because some of them have expired.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, following from the response of the Minister, I want to find out, with the difference of about 7,000 that have not been placed on the payroll since December to July, over six months, what are the difficulties the Ministry is facing in ensuring that all of them are placed on the payroll since they been there for six months?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, the answer to this question was in my submission. I indicated that some of them had their clearance expired.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I will take the last supplementary question.

Yes, you have the floor.

Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan: Mr Speaker, on the issue of managed migration, I wish to find out from the Hon Minister whether this part has not been followed before because I think, in some years past, we had some of these professionals taken abroad. So, I do not understand why we are not putting together the framework.

Is it that what we did the last time came with some difficulties, for which we need a new framework to guide us or, maybe, the Minister just wants to chart a new course?

2.02 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, we have learnt our lessons since then. A lot of things went wrong and we are looking at how we can do them better.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, let us then move to the Question numbered 85 which stands in the name of Dr Kingsley Agyemang, Member of Parliament for Abuakwa.

Hon Member, you have the floor. Because I saw two of you standing, are you sure you have the authority? — *[Laughter]*— Because the authority can be given to only one person.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Novel Perspective of the Ministry on Preventive Medicine

Mr Nana Osei-Adjei on behalf of Dr Kingsley Agyemang (NPP —Abuakwa South): Mr Speaker, I have the authority from my Colleague. So I come under Order 88(3) to seek your permission.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, ask your Question.

Mr Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health the novel perspective of the Ministry on preventive medicine given the high and rising burden of non-communicable diseases.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Burden of non-communicable diseases (NCDs)—

Mr Speaker, Ghana is experiencing a sharp increase in non-communicable diseases (NCDs) such as hypertension, diabetes, stroke, cancers, and chronic kidney disease. These conditions now represent nearly half of all deaths and pose an increasing threat to both the health of our population and the national economy. In Ghana, six out of ten outpatient visits to health facilities are due to NCDs from various causes. These figures may be higher, considering the number of undiagnosed cases and complications observed at health facilities.

Meanwhile, out-of-pocket expenses for treatment and high costs of care often lead to catastrophic health expenditures for patients. This continues to widen the inequity gaps for vulnerable groups and people with low socio-economic status. At the same time, the caregiver burden is increasing. Now, families and relatives must sacrifice their working hours and limited resources to attend to the needs of the patient, particularly those incapacitated by their conditions.

MOH Response

Mr Speaker, as the health, economic, and social impacts of NCDs grow, the Ministry acknowledges the importance of prioritising investments in disease prevention and health promotion measures.

Mr Speaker, please permit me to highlight major initiatives including the Free Primary Healthcare (FPHC) programme and the MahamaCares Fund, which aim to eliminate financial barriers, promote early detection, and support NCD treatment and outreach.

- The FPHC initiative is removing financial barriers to primary care and concentrating on prevention, health promotion, and early diagnosis through a network-based delivery model. It introduces population-based payment mechanisms to incentivise providers to keep people healthy.

- Complementing this, the MahamaCares Initiative is a health fund that supports both treatment and prevention of NCDs, including mobile screening outreach, diagnostics, and awareness campaigns.

- In September, Ghana will include the Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccine in its national immunisation programme, focusing on girls aged 9 to 14. This marks a significant preventative measure against cervical cancer and it is anticipated to avert over 80,000 cases and more than 45,000 deaths in the coming decade.

Mr Speaker, to address NCD risk factors—such as unhealthy diets, inactivity, tobacco, and alcohol use—the Ministry is developing a National Health Promotion Policy. Planned strategies include health check-ups, wellness clinics, healthier food labelling, and promoting active lifestyles. Preventive interventions also include free National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) check-ups and social media health campaigns. Supported by the NCD Policy (2022) and the Ghana WHO STEPwise Approach to NCD Risk Factor Surveillance (STEPS) Report (2024), these initiatives demonstrate the Ministry's commitment to prevention as a route to health equity, economic savings, and national resilience.

Mr Speaker, prevention is not just a health strategy—it is an economic investment. Every cedi spent on early detection and vaccination saves considerably more in future treatment costs. It safeguards productivity, promotes healthier communities, and alleviates long-term fiscal pressure on the health system. The Ministry of Health is dedicated to enhancing disease prevention and health promotion at all levels. Through the Free Primary Healthcare initiative, MahamaCares, the HPV vaccine rollout, and the upcoming Health Promotion Policy, Ghana is creating a more resilient and equitable health system.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Mr Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, in the Minister's submission, he said there is going to be immunisation against HPV in September for girls aged between 9 to 14. I would like to find out if they have an estimate of the number of girls who are going to be vaccinated, the period it is going to take and the costs involved.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, for the information of the House, we have a running programme in agreement with Global Alliance for Vaccines and Immunisation (GAVI). So it is a GAVI-supported programme and as I have stated in the answer, we are targeting to prevent not less than 80,000 of such diseases in the next—we are ruling them in phases, so we co-finance some of the vaccines.

GAVI supports us and through our Budget and the National Health Insurance (NHIA), we also complement. So we are doing about 50-50 funding of vaccines.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Asamoah?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I would like to ask the Hon Minister if he will support compulsory annual wellness visits for Ghanaians at least above the age of 18 and if he would, how are we going to implement this? Because of the insurance policies that are being rolled out.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: A compulsory annual—?

Dr Asamoah: Wellness checkup visits. It is not only when you are sick that you have to go to —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Minister?

Dr Asamoah: If I can finish up, please. So, and if he will, which year do you intend to implement that?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I would not say we will have to make it compulsory. I would prefer to say I would encourage people to routinely do their checkups. Under the current arrangement, there is a provision in the National Health Insurance arrangement.

Thank you.

Mr Osei-Adjei — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you cannot ask a Question, resume, and then want to come back and ask a Question again. The rules do not support that. We then move to the Question numbered 127 which stands in the name of Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah, Member of Parliament for Old Tafo.

Detailed Report on the Current State of the Maternity Ward at Tafo Government Hospital

Mr Vincent Ekow Assifuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health to provide a detailed report on the current state of the construction of the maternity ward at the Tafo Government Hospital, when it is expected to be completed and to indicate if Government has plans to ensure its prompt completion.

2.12 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Minister for Health (Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh) (MP): Mr Speaker, the Government of Ghana, through the Ministry of Health, identified the need for the expansion and modernisation of the Maternity ward at the Tafo Government Hospital as a priority intervention to improve maternal and neonatal health outcomes in the Ashanti Region. The Project, which started in 2005 under GoG/HIPC funding, faced a lot of challenges (with the funding), which led to the stalling of the Project.

The Ministry in 2020 took a bold step to arrange external funding to complete the Project. In pursuit of this objective, the Ministry undertook all the necessary preparatory steps and secured the required Executive approval for a financing arrangement. Subsequently, Parliamentary approval was obtained for both the financing agreement and the associated supply and construction contracts.

Furthermore, Mr Speaker, Value for Money (VFM) assessments and negotiations were successfully completed, ensuring the financial and technical viability of the project. However, Mr Speaker, the implementation of the project was regrettably delayed following the suspension of ongoing projects in December 2022 by the previous administration, occasioned by the national debt restructuring exercise, which adversely impacted the conclusion of the requisite financing arrangements. Consequently, the actual commencement of construction works remain uncertain at this time. The Ministry of Health in collaboration with the Ministry of Finance (MoF) will consider resuming the process once the Government is able to conclude the debt restructuring exercise.

We appreciate the patience of the people of Tafo and the Kumasi metropolis and reaffirm our commitment to complete the Project for the benefit of the people.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Assafuah: Rightly so Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I am very surprised with the kind of Answer I have gotten from the Minister, owing to the fact that consistently, for the past four years, from 2021—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, will you respect Standing Order 88(7) and proceed to ask a supplementary question?

Mr Assafuah: Respectfully, I am asking a supplementary question, but I just want to give a brief background to the matter, because the previous Finance Minister came to this floor when I asked this same Question in 2023.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, supplementary question.

Mr Assafuah: I will crave your indulgence that you allow me to lay a foundation so that you would understand—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, ask a supplementary question.

Mr Assafuah: On paragraph 4 of the Hon Minister's Answer, he stated that the implementation of the project was regrettably delayed following the suspension of ongoing projects in December, 2022 by the previous administration, which was occasioned by the National Debt Restructuring Exercise. I am asking, can you confirm that this is indeed the case, because your previous Minister told us that it is a turf war between the contractor who earned the contract in 2005 and that of the government. Can he confirm that this is the case?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I am not aware of any turf war between anybody. What I know as a fact is that the financing of the project has been affected by the debt restructuring.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a constituency-specific question. We will now move to the Question numbered 194.

Hon Members, Question number 194 standing in the name of Hon Peter Lanchene Toobu, Member of Parliament for Wa West.

Completion of Three Abandoned Health Centre in the Wa West District

Supt Rtd Peter Lanchene Toobu (NDC — Wa West): Mr Speaker, thank you so much for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health when the construction of the following three (3) health centres in the Wa West District, which have been abandoned since 2017, will be completed: (i) Gurungu (ii) Vieri (iii) Eggu.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister?

Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh: Mr Speaker, the Health Centres at

Gurungu, Vieri, and Eggu in the Wa West District form part of a set of primary health care facilities, initiated by the Ghana Health Service (GHS) in 2012. These projects were designed to enhance access to primary healthcare services in support of the Ministry of Health's goal of achieving Universal Health Coverage.

The construction of these facilities was financed through direct budgetary allocations from the Government of Ghana. Currently, the structures have been roofed and plastered. However, progress has stalled primarily due to irregular and insufficient release of funds under the Government of Ghana's budget.

Mr Speaker, as you may be aware, the Government has issued a directive to the Local Government and Rural Development (LGRD) instructing the District Assembly to utilise part of their Common Fund allocation to complete at least two projects in their districts.

We therefore recommend that the Wa West District Assembly utilises part of their Common Fund allocation to complete these projects as soon as possible.

Additionally, the Ministry of Health will support with the necessary logistics to enhance operations.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Supt Rtd Toobu: Mr Speaker, I do not have a supplementary other than commending the Minister for the assurance that if they are completed, the

Minister of Health will be available to support them with the necessary logistics. I am so grateful.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

We then move to Question number 156, standing in the name of Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie, Member of Parliament for Odododiodioo Constituency.

Measures to Address Shortage of Resident Pediatricians at Princess Marie Louise Children's Hospital

Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (NDC — Odododiodioo): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health the measures instituted to address the long-standing shortage of resident paediatricians or doctors at Princess Marie Louise Children's Hospital in Accra.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The PML Children's Hospital has a total of seventeen (17) medical doctors. Out of this, eleven (11) doctors are currently at post whilst six (6) are on approved study leave with pay pursuing various specialisation programmes.

The breakdown of the 11 doctors who are currently at post is as follows:

1. Senior Specialists (Paediatrics) - 2
2. Specialist (Paediatrics) - 1
3. Family Physician- 1
4. Medical Officer
(General Practitioners)- 5
5. Specialist (Dentistry) - 1
6. Medical Officer (Dentist) - 1

The six who are on study leave with pay are pursuing specialisation in the following fields:

1. Paediatrics- 2
2. Family medicine- 1
3. Haematology - 1
4. Anaesthesia - 1
5. Radiology - 1

Measures instituted to address shortages

PML Hospital is managed by the GHS. Generally, as a country we are yet to attain optimal numbers of doctors across the country. This makes it difficult to always have adequate numbers at post. In addition, the attrition amongst medical doctors is also very high; this attrition is driven by our quest to train more specialists and senior specialists as well as the high numbers of doctors that leave for further studies every year. These notwithstanding, the GHS staffing situation of PML is expected to improve in the next few months because of the following:

2.22 p.m.

The two doctors on study leave pursuing paediatrics will soon rejoin the hospital. One will complete in September this year and the other in September, 2026.

The Service has started posting medical doctors directly to the Princess Marie Louise (PML) hospital through the Ministry of Health posting portal because of its peculiar situation. This is part of the overall measures to ensure that medical doctors in the Greater Accra Region are appropriately placed. Having a high number of medical doctors at the hospital will relieve the available paediatricians of attending to minor ailments, allowing them to concentrate on complex cases and improve the quality of care. It will also free the few we have to facilitate the training of an additional number of paediatricians.

This year, 23 more paediatricians will graduate from the Ghana College of Physicians and Surgeons. The GHS will consider re-assigning some of these newly qualified paediatricians to augment the current numbers at PML.

Additionally, the new Children's Hospital at Weija, when completed, will help reduce the current high levels of congestion at the PML and improve access to care for children requiring specialist medical services. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Ashie: Mr Speaker, I first of all want to thank the Minister for Health for honouring my Question. I believe that, of course, these records may exist, but then on the ground, we do not see the paediatricians over there doing their work. So, as a specialised hospital —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Ashie: So, I want to ask the Minister for Health when the paediatricians are going to be seen on the ground working. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, per my records, the paediatricians are in the facility, but if the Hon Member of Parliament, who lives in the constituency is challenging those numbers, I can assure him that we will do a further check and send a team there to verify. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minority Leader?

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, per the answer given by the Minister for Health, I do not think we had the understanding on the number of paediatricians who are currently available. His answer indicated that most of them are in training as we speak now, but I think the question from the Member of Parliament for the Odododiodioo is specifically what number of paediatricians exist at the moment at the hospital.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I wish to repeat the answers for the benefit of the House. The breakdown: Senior specialists (paediatrics) – 2, specialist (paediatrics) – 1, family physician – 1, medical officer (general practitioners) – 5, specialist (dentistry) – 1. Then I said

there are two other paediatrics who are also at training, so they will come back to join this workforce in the facility. So, these are the breakdowns I gave.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question time has ended. I use the opportunity on your behalf to thank the Minister for attending upon the House and responding to Questions scheduled for him. Hon Minister, thank you very much. You are hereby discharged. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Hon Members, may I have the pleasure to acknowledge the presence of Project Abroad. They are led by Theophilus Atujuoa, regional coordinator from Madina Constituency and they are six in number. I welcome you on behalf of the House. May you enjoy a fruitful visit. Kindly resume your seats.

[Members of Project Abroad were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the next item on the Order Paper for today is the item numbered 8, Statement. I understand today is the World Population Day — Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Sorry, Mr Speaker. I wanted to crave your indulgence to seek leave so we can vary the order of Business. The Minister for Health is here, so I wanted to ask the Minister to lay a Paper before he leaves. I discussed it with him, but I turned round and he disappeared.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Deputy Minority Leader, the

application is to vary the order of Business for the Minister for Health.

Ms Appiagyei: I do not think we were in consultation with each other. We needed to have a common understanding because it is one Paper. Anyway—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. We vary the order of Business accordingly and then we take the item numbered 9 —

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: The item numbered 9(b), Mr Speaker, for the Minister for Health.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister for Health, the item numbered 9(b).

PAPER

By the Minister for Health

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the University of Ghana Medical Centre for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Health.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we can then revert to the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. We have a commemorative Statement on World Population Day. We have four Statements and we intend to take all the Statements together. The first Statement is standing in the name of our own Deputy Minority Leader, Hon Patricia Appiagyei.

Ms Appiagyei: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Before I present my Statement to commemorate the World Population Day, I would like to seek your leave to correct a word in my Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, before you do that, let me announce the other Statements, so that after you read your Statement, they will also take theirs, and then we take comments together. The next Statement is standing in the name of Hon Dorcas Toffey, Member of Parliament for Jomoro. The next is Hon Ralph Poku-Adusei, Member of Parliament for Bekwai, and Hon Emmanuel Ntekuni, Member of Parliament for Pru West.

Hon Patricia Appiagyei, you have the floor.

Ms Appiagyei: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I seek your leave to change the word on the second line of my Statement to “globally” and not “nationwide”.

2.32 p.m.

STATEMENTS

Population and Development in Commemoration of World Population Day, 2025

Ms Patricia Appiagyei (NPP — Asokwa): I rise to make this commemorative Statement on the occasion of the World Population Day 2025, which is being observed globally under the national theme, “Empowering the Youth to Create Quality Families in an Inclusive Society”.

Mr Speaker, the observance of the World Population Day is a global reminder of the centrality of the population issues to national development. It offers us an opportunity to reflect on how we, as policymakers, implementers, leaders and duty-bearers, are responding to the demographic realities that shape the lives and future of our people, especially the youth.

In Ghana, young people below the age of 35 make up over 60 per cent of our population. This demographic presents both a challenge and a golden opportunity. The challenge lies in ensuring that they are not left behind in education, health, employment, and civic inclusion. The opportunity lies in harnessing their energies, creativity, and potential to build resilient families and a prosperous nation.

The theme for this year urges us to recognise that empowering the youth, through access to quality education, reproductive health information and services, employment opportunities, and civic participation, is essential in preparing them to form quality families that are healthy, economically stable, and socially inclusive.

Mr Speaker, it is no secret that many of our youth, today, face daunting barriers such as early and unintended pregnancies, child marriages, limited access to family planning, gender-based violence, and economic exclusion which can be found in our various constituencies across the country. These barriers are not only to compromise their individual futures, but also erode the fabric of our society.

Mr Speaker, if we are to reverse these trends, we must commit to implementing youth-focused economic empowerment programmes to enhance their capacity to form and sustain healthy families. We must encourage young people to actively seek knowledge, utilise available services responsibly, engage constructively in civic processes, uphold positive values, and strive for excellence in their chosen fields. We must strengthen reproductive health education to equip our youth with life-saving knowledge, expand access to reproductive health services in youth-friendly, safe, and stigma-free environments, provide digital training and infrastructure to enable the youth to participate in the digital economy.

We must also promote gender equality and discourage harmful norms like child marriage that limit the aspirations of girls and young women. We must invest in youth skills development through apprenticeship and internship, create more entry-level job opportunities, and develop financial products tailored to young entrepreneurs and support an increased financial allocation for the National Population Council Secretariat, which is a policy advisor and has been mandated to coordinate all population and related issues in the country.

Mr Speaker, the Parliamentary Caucus on Population and Development reaffirms its commitment to advocating for laws, policies, and budgets that reflect the needs and aspirations of our youth. World Population Day 2025, is a clarion call to invest in our youth, who are not just the future but the present

drivers of Ghana's progress. By addressing these critical issues: education, productive health, gender equality, and digital inclusion, we can empower young Ghanaians to make informed choices, build resilient families, and contribute to a sustainable economy. We urge our Colleagues in this august House to continue to support initiatives that integrate population variables into development planning at all levels of government.

We also salute the efforts of the National Population Council, the Ministry of Education, Ministry of Health, all other stakeholders, and our development partners, especially United Nation Population Fund (UNFPA) for their continued investment in youth development and population programmes.

As we commemorate this day, let us remember that the quality of our future depends on the investments we make today in our young people, families, and building an inclusive society for all.

On behalf of the Parliamentary Caucus on Population and Development, I respectfully invite this House to join the call to action to empower the youth as drivers of sustainable families and inclusive development.

Let us ensure that no youth is left behind and that every young Ghanaian is given all the necessary tools, knowledge, and opportunity to strive and to lead.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for this opportunity and God bless our youth and God bless Ghana.

Thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Deputy Minority Leader, for this insightful Statement.

The next person to take the Statement is Hon Dorcas Toffey.

You have the floor.

Ms Toffey: Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, my last name is mentioned Toffey, not Toffy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: All right.

Thank you for the correction.

World Population Day, 2025

Ms Dorcas Toffey (NDC — Jomoro): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this important Statement.

Mr Speaker, today, Ghana joins the global community in commemorating World Population Day, a day dedicated to raising awareness of population issues and their critical intersections with development, sustainability, and individual well-being. The theme for this year theme, “Empowering Young People to Create the Families They Want in a Fair and Hopeful World”, calls for significant emphasis on fostering national and global conversations that highlight the impact of population dynamics on socio-economic development, environmental sustainability, and the overall well-being of individuals and families.

2.42 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the population of Ghana is currently estimated at over 33 million,

a figure that reflects both tremendous opportunity and immense responsibility. Our nation, like many across Africa, is blessed with a young and vibrant demographic, with approximately 57 per cent of our citizens under the age of 25. This youthful population presents us with a powerful demographic dividend, but it can only be realised through bold and intentional decisions.

Population growth, in itself, is not a threat. On the contrary, it can be a strategic asset. A growing population brings the promise of an expanded workforce, a more dynamic consumer base and a greater national potential. However, it equally demands that we scale up our systems to meet the rising need for education, healthcare, housing, clean water, sanitation, employment and security.

Mr Speaker, our response to this challenge must be strategic, inclusive and forward-looking. We must prioritise investment in health, especially in maternal and reproductive health services. Empowering individuals and families with access to accurate information and quality services enables informed decisions about family planning, child spacing and personal well-being.

At the same time, our education sector must be restructured to match the demands of the 21st Century. We must ensure that every child, regardless of background or location, has access to inclusive and quality education from basic to tertiary levels. Special focus must be given to Technical and Vocational Education and Training

(TVET), which offers young people practical skills and job readiness in a competitive global market.

Mr Speaker, central to this conversation is the empowerment of women and girls. Their inclusion and advancement are not just matters of justice; they are prerequisites for sustainable development. Keeping girls in school, ending early marriage and safeguarding them from all forms of abuse are key to building resilient families and prosperous communities. When women and girls are empowered, nations thrive.

We must also accelerate efforts to expand decent employment opportunities for our youth. The creation of jobs must grow in tandem with our population. Support for entrepreneurship, skills development and private sector partnerships will be vital to unlocking innovation and productivity across sectors.

Mr Speaker, we face undeniable challenges, from urban congestion and environmental degradation to the mounting pressure on the infrastructure and social services, but these are not insurmountable. They require deliberate planning, coordinated policy interventions and a long-term vision rooted in equity, resilience and sustainability.

As we observe World Population Day, 2025, let us remember that population management is not about numbers; it is about people. It is about creating conditions that allow every Ghanaian to live with dignity, access opportunities and contribute meaningfully to our national journey.

I, therefore, call on all Hon Members and stakeholders from Government, civil society, academia and the private sector to work together in building a Ghana where our population is not seen as a challenge, but as a dynamic force for national development, creativity and progress.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Dorcas Toffey. Did I pronounce the name well now?

Yes, the next to make a Statement is Hon Ralph Poku-Adusei, Member of Parliament for Bekwai. Hon Member, you have the floor?

World Population Day, 2025

Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei (NPP — Bekwai): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement on the commemoration of World Population Day.

Mr Speaker, today, 11th July, 2025, the global community observes World Population Day, a pivotal moment established by the United Nations to spotlight demographic challenges and advance solutions for a sustainable future. The theme for this year, “Empowering young people to create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world”, resonates deeply with the challenges and opportunities facing the youth today.

Mr Speaker, World Population Day traces its roots to 11th July, 1987, when the global population reached 5 billion. In 1989, the United Nations designed this date as an annual call to action, highlighting the interplay between population dynamics, development and human rights. This theme for this year, “Empowering young people to create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world”, reaffirms the promise of the 1994 International Conference on Population and Development that every person has the right to make informed choices about their lives and futures. It also calls for ensuring that young people all over the world have rights, tools and opportunities to shape their futures.

Today, the world counts 1.8 billion young people between the ages of 10 to 24, the largest generation in history. The United Nations Secretary-General, António Guterres emphasised that, “they (young people) are not only shaping our future; they are demanding one that is just, inclusive and sustainable”.

Mr Speaker, as at 2025, the population of Ghana stands at approximately 35.1 million, with a growth rate of approximately 1.85 per cent. Globally, the population has grown significantly since 1987, reaching around 8 billion people. In Ghana, the population has increased from 16 million in 1987 to over 35 million today, with a youthful demographic, where 37.4 per cent of the population is between 0 to 14 and 88.2 per cent aged between 15 to 64 years.

Mr Speaker, the youth population of Ghana, like many countries worldwide,

face challenges that impact their ability to create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world. These challenges include economic insecurity, gender inequality, limited healthcare and education, climate disruption and conflict, which can hinder their potential and aspirations. It is important that we use this day to raise awareness about population issues, promote policies that ensure a sustainable and equitable future and advocate for reproductive health, family planning and gender equality.

Mr Speaker, Ghanaian governments, over the years, in an effort to empower young people and create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world, have demonstrated a commitment to achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) through various initiatives. Some notable interventions include:

- i. Free Senior High School (SHS) Education Policy: Introduced in 2017 to enhance access to education, maximise literacy levels, and promote economic and social development.
- ii. Global School Feeding Programme (GSFP): Aims to enhance food security, reduce hunger and increase school enrolment, attendance and retention.
- iii. Adolescent Reproductive Health Policy (ARHP): Launched in 2016 to provide comprehensive sexual and reproductive health education, increase access to family planning services and reduce teenage pregnancies.

- iv. Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) Program: Provides cash transfer to poor households to reduce poverty and inequality.
- v. National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS): Offers health insurance to Ghanaians, promoting access to healthcare services.
- vi. Ghana COVID-19 Alleviation and Revitalization of Enterprises Support (Ghana CARES) Programme: Collaborates with development partners to invigorate the economy's productive sectors while safeguarding the vulnerable through multi-year flagship interventions.

2.52 p.m.

Mr Speaker, empowering the young people to create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world requires a multifaceted approach, including education, health care, economic opportunities, no poverty and hunger, and recognising and protecting their rights and autonomy to meet the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals, (SDGs). The Constitution of Ghana also provides a framework for promoting the wellbeing and development of young people. Key provisions include, Article 25; the right to education, which is essential for empowering young people, and Article 34; the directive principle of state policy, which emphasises the importance of promoting the welfare of children and young people.

Mr Speaker, to empower young people to create the families they want in

a fair and hopeful world, I also recommend that the government must continue to;

- Invest in Education and Healthcare: Ensure access to quality education and healthcare; particularly, productive health services.
- Provide Economic opportunities by supporting entrepreneurship, build stable and secure future for young people.
- Recognise and protect rights to ensure laws and policies to promote and protect the rights and autonomy of young people, particularly, women and girls.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, empowering young people to create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world is crucial for building a sustainable and equitable future. By investing in education, healthcare, economic opportunities, and rights, we can unlock the potentials of our youth and create a better world for all.

As we commemorate World Population Day, let us reaffirm our commitment to supporting and empowering young people, ensuring they have the opportunities and resources needed to thrive. Let us strive to create a world where every person has access to the resources, education, and healthcare they need to shape their lives with dignity and hope. As the UN Secretary General, Mr Antonio Guterres puts it "Let us stand with young people and build a future where every person can shape their destiny in a world that is fair, peaceful, and full of hope".

Mr Speaker, thank you for this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have the last commemorative Statement, standing in the name of Emmanuel Kofi Ntekuni, MP for Pru East. Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Emmanuel Kofi Ntekuni: Mr Speaker, it is Pru West.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: All right.

World Population Day

Mr Emmanuel Kofi Ntekuni (NDC — Pru West): Mr Speaker, I am profoundly grateful for this pristine opportunity to draw national attention to an issue that lies at the heart of our development, prosperity, and collective future on World Population Day. World Population Day, commemorated annually, serves as a global platform to focus attention on the agency and significance of population issues.

The root of this day traces back to the 11th of July, 1987, the historic day when the world's population reached 5 billion, a milestone that underscored the pressing need to reflect on population trends and their implications for our shared future.

Mr Speaker, each year, the United Nations selects a theme that reflects the evolving population development agenda, guiding nations to examine how population growth impacts social, economic, and environmental outcomes. The theme for this year is “Empowering

young people to create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world”. It reaffirms the promise of the 1994 International Conference on population and development that every person has the right to make informed choices about their lives and future. At the very heart of that promise lies the family, the most fundamental unit of society. Many young people today face economic uncertainty, gender inequality, health challenges, climate crisis and conflict. Still, they are leading with courage, conscience, and clarity. And they are calling for systems that uphold their rights and support their choices.

Mr Speaker, the world's population, according to the United Nations, is now projected to reach an estimate of 8.2 billion and 9.9 billion people by the end of 2025 and 2050 respectively. At the end of 2025, the population of Africa is projected to be approximately 1.54 to 1.55 billion (United Nations, 2025). This rapid increase makes Africa the fastest growing region, home to nearly 19 per cent of the population of the world. Ghana alone contributes approximately 36 million to this figure, representing about 0.43 per cent of the global population. Behind these statistics are real lives, young people yearning for opportunity, women striving for empowerment and families aspiring for dignity and security. It is a reminder that our national agenda must place young people and families at its centre.

According to the United Nations Population Division (2024), many developed countries are experiencing fertility rates well below their

replacement level of 2.1 births per woman, which is necessary to maintain a stable population. Meanwhile, in many developing countries, including those on our continent, Africa, families are confronted with an entirely different set of realities, with rapid population growth, high fertility rates, and persistent socio-economic barriers that limit young people, especially young women from making informed choices about marriage, childbearing, and family life.

Mr Speaker, according to the latest data from the Ghana Statistical Service and the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), the current total fertility rate in Ghana stands at approximately 3.6 children per woman. This represents a gradual decline from a total fertility rate of 4.2 in 2010 and over 6.4 in the 1980s, signaling progress in reproductive health education and services.

3.02 p.m.

However, it is worth noting that while the national average shows a downward trend, significant disparities exist. Rural areas still record higher fertility rates, around 4.4 children per woman, compared to 2.8 in urban areas. This shows that Ghana's total fertility rate of 3.6 is higher than the global average currently estimated at 2.3 births per woman, but it aligns with broader demographic trends of sub-Saharan Africa, which remains one of the fastest-growing regions in the world.

Early and unintended pregnancies, lack of access to sexual and reproductive health education, unemployment, and

economic pressures often constrain young Ghanaians from building the families they truly desire.

Mr Speaker, as articulated in the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals 3 and 5, which demand that we meet the needs of today without compromising the ability of future generations to meet theirs, it calls for a delicate balance between economic growth, social inclusion, gender equality, environmental protection, and respect for human rights.

Mr Speaker, as we join the global community to celebrate this day, we must recognise the fundamental human rights of every individual, especially young people, to make informed decisions about if, when, and how many children they wish to have. But these choices do not happen in isolation. They are influenced by education, access to health care, economic circumstances, climate change, and cultural factors.

This reality presents both opportunities and challenges. On one hand, our youthful population offers the potential for demographic dividend, where a large, educated, and empowered workforce drives economic growth. On the other hand, high fertility rates, if unmanaged, can strain health care systems, deepen poverty, and hinder sustainable development.

Mr Speaker, I believe we are on the right path, and I say this with confidence, especially in light of the tireless effort and goodwill demonstrated by H. E. John Dramani Mahama, a Leader whose

unwavering commitment to human development, population management, and job creation continues to resonate across Ghana.

Under this renewed leadership, we are witnessing bold, people-centred policies that directly empower our youth, giving them the tools, dignity, and voice to shape their own future. Mr Speaker, this Government is listening and responding. Let us stand with the young people and build a future where every person can shape their destiny in a world that is fair, peaceful, and full of hope.

As rightly put by Kofi Annan, former UN General-Secretary, a nation that fails to invest in its young people mortgages its future. This requires that the Government of Ghana takes population issues more seriously to also fulfil the spirit enshrined in Article 37(4) of the 1992 Constitution of the country, which states that:

“The state shall maintain a population policy consistent with the aspirations and development needs and objectives of Ghana”.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for this opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Statements are duly delivered and by agreement.

Yes?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Thank you very much Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, initially, we agreed that we will do three

Statements on population; three from each Side, but Hon Quayson did not read his Statement. So now, we have four Statements on population. We are trying to do three from each Side plus Leadership, making eight.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I have no objection, except to remind him that at Conclave; the decision was that we move with the light of speed on the Bill but if it is your pleasure that we have even 10 each, I have no issues.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: My Brother, if a decision has been taken by Conclave —

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, it comes back to the same 10 because after the three each contribution, we will come back to contribute on Hon Quayson's Statement. So, we have added that of Hon Quayson to make four Statements. Which means we have added one each as if we are contributing towards Hon Quayson's Statement. So, we come back to the same point.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, I do not have that Statement before me. But Hon Member, when Statements are admitted, they are supposed to be programmed and copies made available for Members. Now the four Statements that we are taking, we have it uploaded on the console. But the fifth one that we are talking about is not here. So, if he wants to use the opportunity, instead of making a Statement, contribute to the Statement, then he should be one of the contributors.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the point I am making is that, we made provision for Hon Quayson. We could not find his Statement. As a result, he is not reading that Statement. So, we are done with reading of Statements. Now we are going to contribute to the Statements made by Hon Members.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, we are speaking the same language. If you will be one of the contributors, that decision is decided on your Side. You understand? It is not a matter to be agreed upon. So, I got the sense. So, now Statements are duly presented, and it is for your comment and as agreed, two each, and the Leadership will conclude. So, the indication is that Hon Quayson will be one of the people commenting on the Statement. Is that it?

Hon Member for Kwesimintsim, you have the floor.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, he is not contributing to the Statement. But the outstanding Statement is for Hon Felicia.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then Hon Member for Kwesimintsim, you have the floor.

Mr Philip Kofi Buckman (NDC — Kwesimintsim): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. May I commend the makers of the Statements.

Mr Speaker, it is very important that we commend them. The theme which they have all succinctly spoken on is empowering the youth.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we need to be brief. If you want to go beyond the five minutes, I will cut you.

Mr Buckman: Yes. Empowering the youth to create families in an inclusive society. Empowering the youth is not only about health or education, but it is also about empowering them to have that mental fortitude as future leaders, as future family makers of the society. We all agree, and it is succinctly couched in our Constitution, that the family is the basic unit on which all societies are built. That is why the theme resonates with good and sound reasoning, creating quality families in an inclusive society. If families break down, if we do not create quality families, we are going to produce people that are going to be a burden on the society and that is why I rise to support this clarion call. It is not just a commemorative one, but it is something that we should all accept. Religious leaders, traditional leaders, schools, wherever, policy makers, we make it a point to ensure that we create great families, bigger and better families, that would help our society to grow. On this note, I would want to humbly commend the makers of the Statements.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Yes, Hon Kabiru, be brief.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Firstly, I would like to thank the lead Statement made by the Leader, Hon

Patricia Appiagyei, Hon Ralph, and Colleagues from the other Side for these commemorative Statements.

3.12 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I want to touch briefly on the cardinal issue of the Statement. The maker of the first Statement drew our attention to the fact that over 60 per cent of our population is over the age of 35. Mr Speaker, those below the age of 35 present us with two contrasting things, the demographic dividend and the demographic disaster. The demographic dividend is the opportunities that this particular group of people presents for economic development. And the demographic disaster is the converse. That is the lack of action and the threat this population presents to the country.

First, on the demographic dividend, Mr Speaker, a youthful population is a catalyst for economic development. And while we have the population being under the age of 25, we definitely expect that a country so minded will use this population so well to enhance the development. But in our case, we seem to have a huge chunk of the youth being unemployed. And that is a disaster that we have to deal with.

Mr Speaker, we can do something about this situation. We can, as a country, prioritise how we make the youth the centre of our development. Technical education is one. One of the makers of a Statement drew our attention to the fact that while we want our youth to have employable skills, the employability of our youth is very

important. And once we prioritise technical education, Mr Speaker, we will be able to do something and turn our demographic disaster into a demographic dividend.

Mr Speaker, another issue that we need to look at is that basic education should have entrepreneurial traits. In other words, we must imbibe at the basic, at the core, entrepreneurial education so that the youth will be able to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Dr Mahama: On this note, Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings, you have the floor.

Ms Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings (NDC— Klottey Korle): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statements made by the Hon Members under the theme of Global Population Day, which is; empowering young people to create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world.

Mr Speaker, Africa has the most youthful population globally, and it is also the most resource-rich and has a huge landmass. If we are to effectively develop our countries by having effective decentralisation and equitable distribution of our resources, we will

actually discover that the hype that is out there about Africa being overpopulated is untrue. Because if we have proper distribution of resources, proper governance and decentralisation, we will discover that we will be able to put a halt to the rural-urban drift, and find that our population is actually not over the limit.

Mr Speaker, I believe that if we are to really give hope to young people to have quality families, it also starts with providing a situation of stability, security and peace. Across the continent, we have too many areas where we have conflict and a lack of stability. We have so many disasters, as well as the emergence of violent extremism.

Mr Speaker, it is impossible for people to think about having families when they are thinking of survival mode. So, we have a duty as governments across the continent to really provide a situation of stability and peace in order to be able to satisfy this particular provision for the youth to have a fair and hopeful world.

Mr Speaker, our national security, our global security, are a threat to this particular theme, and it starts with good governance. Mr Speaker, across the sub-region, whether it is in the Sahel or even closer to home, in Bawku, or even in Greater Accra, the levels of conflict and violence are getting increasingly disturbing, and the youth are constantly being blamed.

But the youth are not in position of leadership or governance. So government must take account of the aspirations of the youth in order to make sure they are not forgotten at the decision-making

table. So that when we expect that they will have youthful families that have quality of life, it is based on the fact that there is an environment that makes provision for it.

Mr Speaker, we have a duty as representatives to ensure that our various governments are giving the chance for young people to have families, to have access to the right kind of funding, to be able to support themselves, to support their businesses, and to ensure quality education of their children as well as good healthcare.

And so, Mr Speaker, I do add my voice to the makers of the various statements that we have to have a collective action to ensure that this theme is actually realised. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, by the agreement, we have done two from here. Then we use the opportunity to take a Statement standing in the name of Hon Felicia Adjei, MP for Kintampo, on immigration and returnees.

Hon Member, you have the floor. Is he on his feet because I did not see anybody here? We want to take two on each Side.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The agreement was that we put all the Statements together, which we have dispensed of. Then we will have two a piece, two from each Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, I have taken two from the left Side, one

from the Right. Then I turned, looking at this Side, nobody was up.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, when you finish, you still have to come to Leadership before you go to this—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so if the Leadership is not up, the presumption is that—You have the floor.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I wish to speak. My Colleague is signalling to me that he wants to speak, but Mr Speaker, we are in your hands. If it is your pleasure.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I am not the one who will agree and come here and do otherwise.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I will speak. I commend you, Mr Speaker, for your indulgence and for the masterpiece for ensuring that all three Statements are delivered at the same time. And then the decision to ensure that we could speak on these Statements as a whole.

I think fundamental concerns have been raised, and not to repeat the issues that Colleagues have spoken about. I tend to share in the many things that Colleagues have spoken about; the positive and the negative derivatives of population dynamics, and what have you.

Mr Speaker, it is said that Africa has the youngest population. No doubt about it, but clearly, we are sleeping on that

huge potential. We are not taking advantage of it. So, there is a call that we should be able to take advantage of our young population. That itself is a resource; a resource in its dormant state that must be enhanced and used to its fullest potential. That for me is a matter we cannot toil with.

Mr Speaker, we are also having the drifting of population from our countryside to the urban centres. So, our cities are becoming overpopulated and the attendant effect on infrastructure and facilities in our cities. This comes in the wake and a call on duty bearers—And the cross-cutting issues that the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs and other duty bearers should bring their minds to.

The Hon Member, one of the Colleagues who presented a Statement, made a passing reference to the Brundtland Commission. Brundtland, who is a Dutch expert, who had—Yes, I see my good Friend, the Majority Chief Whip, referencing the year. Brundtland is a Dutch authority on the sustainable usage of resources for today and the future. That has been made. The United Nations (UN) has taken some resolutions on these matters. So, we do not need to rehash.

3.22 p.m.

However, Mr Speaker, and I know we are constrained by time. The imperative of the Directive Principles of State Policy, specifically Article 37 of the Constitution, is clear on equitable distribution of resources. One can argue

that, well, the Directive Principles of State Policy is not justiciable. But these are very important guides, both to the Executive, the Legislature and other Government officials and we should be adverting our minds to it.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, we have a state institution, the National Population Council (NPC), which bears direct responsibility in such matters. It is regrettable that the National Population Council is, more or less, for want of a better expression, at the beck and call of international donors. Real budgetary provision from the state and Government — and here I am not saying just the NDC Government, but governments that have come and gone — has always scratched the surface of the concerns of the National Population Council, so we are committed to achieving on these key deliverables because of their connectivity, in terms of poverty reduction, food sustainability, and food availability, then we should be paying attention to it.

I am happy that the respected Deputy Minority Leader, I see my good Friend and other notable personalities who have taken key interest in population concern. I hope it does not become a nine-day wonder where we put on our branded t-shirts and then when we finish, we let the matters rest. So, I pray we can sustain the campaign and then we can all achieve and help in achieving what we are all desirous of achieving.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to the Statement ably made by four Hon Members of this House, led by our Deputy Minority Leader, Ms Patricia Appiagyei.

Mr Speaker, the theme for World Population Day this year is “Empowering young people to create the families they want in a fair and hopeful world”. That simply means that we, the political elites, leadership of this country, should give the young people hope. They need hope to be able to create the kind of fairness we are talking about. The population of the world, as it stands today, is just over 8 billion. In fact, it became 8 billion, I think, on the 15th November, 2022. The population of Africa, as has been mentioned, is about 1.5 billion and Ghana’s own is almost about 34 million when it was last counted.

Mr Speaker, that obviously means that there is going to be strain on services that the Government provides for our people, including these young people. It means that we need to relook at the way we use our resources for the benefit of these young people who we are trying to create an equitable, fair, and hopeful society for.

Mr Speaker, one of the lessons as well is that we the political elite or those who lead the country should not be over-borrowing to leave debt for this future

generation. Because if we do, they will not be able to create the families that they want because they will spend their time, basically, paying the debt that we have left them.

Mr Speaker, it is clear, and it has been said many times, that the population of Africa is significantly a youthful one. In Africa, the biggest chunk of the population are people below the age of 25. In Ghana, the bulk of our population is actually young people, and the biggest problem we have today is unemployment. That is a time bomb. If we do not create a conducive atmosphere to be able to create jobs for our young people, they can never achieve the creation of the families they want and have a fair and hopeful world.

Mr Speaker, it is important, therefore, that we create policies and programmes that will enable our young people to be able to get jobs, as is being done currently. I wish the young people well. I hope that they participate in all activities of this country and I pray that we, who are managing the economy of this country, give the young people opportunity to be part of the future that we are creating or planning for them.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will briefly take the Statement standing in the name of Hon Felicia Adjei, Member of Parliament for Kintampo South, so that we can take one each contributions and then we move to the Bill.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Emigration and Returnees

Ms Felicia Adjei (NPP — Kintampo South): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement. I am here today to talk about why many young people from Kintampo South go to places like Libya and what happens when they come back. A lot of Ghanaians leave the country looking for better life somewhere, and come back after many years. This affects families, the economy, and the progress of the country.

Mr Speaker, many people leave because they cannot find jobs; there are not enough opportunities and life can be hard here. As a result, we lose smart and talented people who could help build Ghana. Even though different Governments have tried to help people find jobs and start businesses, many young people are still struggling because of lack of money, different routes, and little support. But those who return home also bring hope. They come back with new skills and experience that can help Ghana grow.

Mr Speaker, we need to welcome them and help them succeed. Sadly, many young people with great ideas either give up or leave the country. Many young people are unaware of the dangers associated with irregular immigration. We need to teach them the truth using schools, churches, community leaders, and social media. Our system does not support them enough to start and grow successful businesses. Mr Speaker, that is why I suggest we do more to help more

businesses grow and create jobs. Programmes like National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme (NEIP) and Microfinance and Small Loans Centre (MASLOC) have helped a bit, but we need stronger people and a stronger plan that brings all these efforts together.

Mr Speaker, in 2020, the Minister for Business Development and the private sector formed a seven-member committee to lead the drafting and advocate for the passage of the Ghana Innovation and Startup Bill. My check indicates that the Bill is at the consideration of the technical working committee. So, I am appealing to Government to fast-track the work of the committee, formulate the set-up acts, especially a law that will make it easy to start businesses, help young people get money and training, protect their ideas, and encourage teamwork, bring together all the help from governments and donor groups.

Mr Speaker, other countries like Nigeria and Kenya have already passed similar laws and it is helping their young people succeed. So, I ask Parliament to support the Ghana Innovative Startup Bill. Let us give our young entrepreneurs the tools they need to build successful businesses and help Ghana grow.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

3.32 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, I will take one comment from each Side, if any.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Nelson Kofi Djabab (NDC — Krachi East): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity granted me to contribute to the Statement made by Hon Felicia Adjei on the reasons young people exit Ghana for greener pastures elsewhere.

Mr Speaker, it is true that most young women and men of our country, Ghana, now travel outside the country purposely with the aim to search for white-collar jobs where they think it exists, but it is rather not true that they get these white-collar jobs. Most often than not, social media has made us see that most of our young people who travel outside Ghana have found themselves in some conditions that are more deplorable and harder than even their living conditions while they were here in Ghana.

That is why it is important that the government policies we have here, like the LEAP and MASLOC, should be protected. But, Mr Speaker, the unfortunate situation is that, as much as I have known, there is no free manna falling anywhere in the world. Governments, over the years, have tried to sustain these programmes, but when people go for such loans or facilities to better their living conditions, they sometimes think that it is free money and repayment becomes a problem. Whereas this was supposed to be a revolving kind of fund where one takes it and returns it,

so that someone who is next to them can also get it, and by so doing, we can gradually develop young people, get capital and work with this capital to better their lives.

It is for this reason, I would like to appeal to our young people in Ghana that such policies by governments, as we have, like MASLOC and LEAP, are there to better their conditions. They are not free moneys that will be given to them, they take and refuse to pay. If one takes such facilities and does not pay back, they are doing harm to their brother or sister who would have benefitted from such social intervention.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to this Statement. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (NPP — Kwabre East): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

I must say that travelling for greener pastures has its pros and cons. Mr Speaker, most of us here, in this Parliament, have travelled for one reason or the other and have stayed there to better our education, better the lot of our families, or even just for recreational purposes. Mr Speaker, people travel to gather critical life experiences and life hacks that help them and train them in areas of discipline, hard work, punctuality at work and embracing diversity because they get to interact with people from all walks of life and engage them in work, education and other disciplines. Respect for human

rights can also be learnt while abroad and also, furthering of one's education.

Mr Speaker, however, some people travel under very perilous circumstances. For example, the people who travel through the desert, through Libya to go to either Spain or Italy, undergo very perilous circumstances in order to even get to their final destination to seek for greener pastures. These are the things that we should talk about.

Mr Speaker, the other negative consequence of travelling outside is brain drain.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: We have also seen videos of mostly women going through very difficult and inhumane circumstances in Arab countries.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I would like to call for a concerted effort from our Government to ensure that we could seek opportunities for our people who are travelling and make it a regularised programme, so that our embassies would take charge of Ghanaians travelling to the various countries and keep track of them, the jobs they are doing and whatever they are doing there. So that when they go through difficult circumstances, we can be there to support our citizens who travel outside.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leadership, any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have come to the end of Statements time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Statement time has ended. The Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025 under consideration.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

[Pause]

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025

[Resumption of Consideration from 10/07/25]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think we stopped at clause 50. We have done clause 50. Is that not so? We are moving to clause 51.

Clause 51 — Importation of vessel to engage in fishing and fishing-related activities.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Chairman of the Committee (Dr Godfred Seidu Jasaw): Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there is no advertised amendment. It is for the consideration of the House; any proposed amendments?

Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I wish to bring to your attention and possibly for consideration, the fact that “operation” under clause 51(1) should be *deleted*. With your permission, I take it:

“A person shall not import a vessel for fishing operations or fishing-related activities unless the importation is approved by the Ministry.”

Mr Speaker, respectfully, I submit that if you look at clause 51(2), it justifies my position that there is no consistency. Clause 51(2) says that:

“Subject to the Ghana Shipping Act, 2003, (Act 645), the Commission shall make a recommendation to the Ghana Maritime Authority for the registration of vessels to engage in fishing and fishing-related activities.”

So, Mr Speaker, it is my take, respectfully, that we *delete* “operations” in subclause (1).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, that is the proposal, but do you not think that in the second line, the word “engage” was used?

Mr Afriyie: Absolutely. Say that again, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: They used the word “engage”.

Mr Afriyie: No, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In clause 51(2), the words used are “vessels to engage in”.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, my position is that if you look at it, it is like an unnecessary repetition because “fishing operations” and “fishing-related activities”—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is for the consideration of the House.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, respectfully, let me urge my Brother to withdraw the amendment because sub-clause (1) is about the importation of the vessel; that is a separate transaction. Sub-clause (2) is about engagement; it could be for a short period. So, there are two different scenarios being referenced in sub-clauses (1) and (2).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Chairman of the Committee, what do we say? We need to truncate these arguments on the Floor.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, this has come up before and I was advised that if it is importation of the vessels, it comes for a lot of things, including fishing operations. So, it has to be fishing operations and fishing-related activities, which can then be research, survey, data collection, other related things, *et cetera*. So, Mr Speaker, the Committee thinks that the current rendition is appropriate; it conveys the meaning properly and it should be allowed to stay.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Hon Kabiru Mahama?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Hon Member is drawing our attention to the fact that previous provisions have stated that “fishing and fishing-related activities”, but in this one, we are using “fishing operations”, which to me, if we leave it at “fishing and fishing-related”, it is consistent with the previous rendition. That is the point he is making.

3.42 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Can you show us the previous rendition?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I will need a moment, not this current one.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That was not what the Hon Member said.

Dr Mahama: So, what I am saying is that we have had this rendition before, this is not the first time it is appearing and it has always been “fishing and fishing-related activities”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will direct the drafters to ensure consistency. Very well, is it approved by the Ministry or by the Minister?

Dr Jasaw: It is “Approved”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Approved by the Ministry or the Minister in clause 51? Is it Minister or Ministry?

Dr Jasaw: It is “approved by the Ministry and endorsed by the stakeholders”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 51(1) is saying “A person shall not import a vessel for fishing operations or fishing-related activities unless the importation...”

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it should be by the Minister; that is the standard.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why I am asking whether it is the Minister or Ministry that is giving the approval.

Mr Dafeamekpor: It is the Minister, the office holder.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee, what do you say?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, it is so. I did not get you the first time. It is the Minister, please.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, delete in clause 51(1) the last word “Ministry” and insert “Minister”.

Dr Mahama: I just want to point out that when we look at the application of the Act, it says “(b) fishing and fishing-related activities”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why I directed the drafters to correct it for us.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko — *rose* —

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 51 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, getting up early is part of the game. You do not wait till the question is being put, then you try to arrest it.

Clause 52 — Construction of artisanal or semi-industrial fishing vessel.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any proposed amendment? It is for the consideration of the House. Hon Members, when I say amendment is for the consideration of the House, that is where Members will get up to propose the amendment.

Yes, Dr Mahama?

Dr Mahama: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am proposing an insertion of a phrase. Clause 52(2) should read:

“For the purpose of subsection (1), the Commission shall collaborate with the Ghana Maritime Authority, the Ghana National Canoe Carvers Association, traditional leaders, and other relevant agencies as the case may be for the construction of an artisanal or semi-industrial fishing vessel.”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if you introduce “as the case

may be”, it means you want them to pick and choose.

Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, in fact, that is why the phrase introduced “relevant”. So, once it is relevant, then they may be consulted. Because “as the case may be” also means relevant. So “relevant” takes care of “as the case may be” and means as and when they are necessary.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am guided, but I was making this point because traditional rulers in some cases is specified clearly, but in other cases, we may not need to involve or engage traditional rulers. But if we mention it explicitly —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what is the word “relevant” doing in the phrase?

Dr Mahama: No, “relevant” is not in reference to traditional rulers.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No. Traditional rulers are mentioned explicitly, specifically. And they are saying “other relevant agencies”. The relevance of “other relevant agencies” is not in respect of the traditional rulers; that is the point I am making.

I am saying that for the fear that traditional rulers may sometimes demand, when the case does not demand that they are engaged —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Who are the traditional rulers? When we go to our coastal areas, is there any coastal area without a traditional ruler?

Dr Mahama: No, it is not only about a coastal area.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kingsley Nyarko, let me hear you.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect, yesterday, I took the Bill home to read. When you called for any other issue, we were looking at clause 51 (1). After it was done, I rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, we are now on clause 52. Do you have an amendment on clause 52?

Prof Nyarko: I did not arrest any Chamber. I am saying that if you do that, with respect —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you have an amendment to clause 52?

Clause 52 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 53 and 54 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 55 — Refusal of permit to construct artisanal or semi-industrial fishing vessel.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I would like to seek some clarification from the Chairman. Clause 55(1) outlines certain conditions prevalent why the Commission may refuse to grant the permit, and it outlines (a), (b), (c), (d). I want to ask the Chairman, if a person satisfies these four conditions, is it a requirement that the Commission will grant the permit?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, there are parts. There is a separate section that details requirements for granting of permit.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further consideration?

Clause 55 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 56 — Prohibition of fishing or fishing-related activities without a fishing licence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment, please.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I humbly suggest that we take “fishing” qualifying the “licence” out of the headnote. So, it reads, “prohibition of fishing or fishing-related activities without a licence.”. Because the entire regime is about the fishing licence, so we do not need to repeat “fishing licence”, in my humble view.

Mr Speaker, let me disengage.

Clause 56 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 57 — Types of fishing licences.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Yes, Hon Asamoah?

3.52 p.m.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Clause 57(1), “For the purpose of fishing or fishing-related activities under this Act, the Commission shall, subject to the approval of the Minister, issue the following fishing licences.”

Mr Speaker, this Commission has a governing board and the board should be given the powers to grant these fishing licences. If you look at the Gold Board,

the approval of licences is given to the Gold Board, so I suggest that we replace it with either the Governing Board or replace it with the Commission.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Asamoah, in this case the alter ego of the Commission is the Board. That is the distinction between calling it Gold Board.

Dr Asamoah: Yes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This one is the Commission, but the alter ego of the Commission is the Board. The Commission itself, per se, cannot take a step. It is the Board, so the act of the Commission is the act of the Board.

Dr Asamoah: Yes. Mr Speaker, it should be explicit here because we are saying that the Governing Board of the Commission does not have the power to grant licences but has to be subject to the Ministry that has to grant the licences.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Member may avert his mind to the amendment we effected in section 51(1), that it is the Minister who is being empowered to grant the licence.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 57 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 58 — Qualification for licence to operate Ghanaian fishing vessel.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I will first seek clarification from the Chairman and probably that will inform whether my amendment still holds. Section 58(1) (a) reads:

“A Ghanaian fishing vessel is a fishing vessel:

owned or controlled by a citizen, the Government, or owned or controlled by a company or partnership registered by law in the Republic and the share of which is beneficially owned wholly by the Government.”

Mr Speaker, my emphasis is ‘beneficially owned wholly by the Government, a citizen, a public corporation established by law in the Republic or a combination of any of them’.

Mr Speaker, I wanted to find out why we have to introduce this because we know that a Ghanaian company is defined by law, that is incorporated in Ghana with majority shareholders being Ghanaians, and that is the definition of a Ghanaian company. If that is right, why do we have to introduce this one here? Maybe I am getting a different meaning of that.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, but before asking the Chairman to respond, is this in contravention with the principle that a Ghanaian company means a company wholly or partly owned?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, my difficulty is on the provision that the beneficial ownership should be wholly Ghanaian. That is what my understanding of this particular provision is on. So, if they say beneficial ownership should be wholly Ghanaian, is that the position of what a Ghanaian company is? That is just the clarity I wanted from the Chairperson in respect of that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I am clear in my mind, but Hon Chairman?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, in discussing this particular provision, there was extensive reference to the Companies Act as amended, and we are seeking by this provision to cure a certain practice, which is that we need the beneficial owners of companies in the industry known, because they are examples of Ghanaians fronting for companies when proceeds and other benefits, these are natural resources that should come to Ghana and Ghanaians, does not really come. And so, this provision is aiming to cure that kind of gap in our resource benefit for citizens in this country. And so, the era where fronting for people and the ownership and benefits and proceeds of this resource going out to those people will be curtailed by this provision.

Dr Mahama: Mr speaker, you are an authority in this, I will yeild, if it is alright.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, let us say Dr Kabiru is a Nigerian, and we registered a company in Ghana. The company is registered in Ghana as a Ghanaian company, however, you, the

Nigerian, holds all the shares, though the company is registered in Ghana. That is what this is seeking to cure. In that particular case, for purposes of certification and licencing to operate as a Ghanaian fishing vessel, it will not be classified as a Ghanaian fishing vessel, because the beneficial ownership, which is the share of the company, is not owned by a Ghanaian; a citizen of Ghana, but it is a citizen of Nigeria. That is the difference. Though the company is registered in Ghana, is incorporated in Ghana.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, to the extent that it would not conflict with the Companies Act, I yield.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is not in conflict.

Any further? Yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: And to allay his fears, normally we use the Regulation to flesh out the incidents of what constitutes control.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 58 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 59 — Application for licence to operate Ghanaian industrial fishing vessel.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, section 59(2)(w), I would want to find out, in the event that a company or a vessel has no history of infractions, is it still important

that the report is attached? If there is no history of infractions, is that report still necessary to be attached?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, it will be straightforward, if there is no history, the report would say so.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 59 ordered to stand part of the bill.

Clause 60 — Application for licence to operate Ghanaian semi-industrial fishing vessel.

Dr Mahama Mr Speaker, section 60(2)(e), We have “where applicable”. I want to find out why we have to qualify that because of the statutory nature of social security and insurance trust law? Why do we have to qualify that?

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Dr Kabiru, here we are talking about social security. A person above 60 years can operate, but such a person is not entitled to contribute social security.

4.02 p.m.

That is why they are indicating where it is applicable, so there are instances where it will not be applicable. In this House, Members of Parliament above 60 years do not contribute Social Security, so it is not applicable to them.

Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, my other concern is about the consistency of labelling the licence and in some headnotes we say “fishing licence” and others we eliminate the “fishing”, so if Table could —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will direct the drafters to be consistent in the use of the language.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Exactly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Mahama?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, still on clause 60(2)(l), “proof of ownership”. To ensure consistency, a similar rendition is in clause 59(2)(p), “a hire purchase agreement or bill of sale”. Bill of sale specifically is a proof of ownership and we are saying proof of ownership here. Is it alright to repeat clause 59(1)(p) in the place of clause 60(2)(l) because basically, it is the same. I just want to first be sure that they were talking about the same thing then I can propose amendments to that effect.

Thank you Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Well, Mr Speaker, clause 59(2)(p) is specific and then 60(2)(l) is proof of ownership, so it can go beyond what is itemised in clause 59(2)(p). So, if one has further proof of ownership, what does it say? How does it justify that it is for the person? So, one proves beyond reasonable doubt that it is actually his or

hers. I think that increases transparency and the object here is to demonstrate transparency in this kind of licence issuance.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, then to ensure consistency as we all said, then we should rather replace clause 59(2)(p) with proof of ownership so that abundantly, we know that we are talking about the same thing. But if here we are saying bill of sale or hire purchase agreement which is basically a proof of ownership and here, we come to mention specifically proof of ownership without the —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The distinctions are very clear, Dr Mahama. If somebody is proving ownership of purchase, that is a different thing. If I have a document to show that I am the owner of this, it is also a different thing. So, it does not cause any harm to the provision. Does it cause any harm to the provision?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, for instance in the interim, I may be in possession of an 8-cylinder engine vehicle (V8). I may hire the vehicle for say, a week and for official purposes it is in my possession. I am driving it. I can also do a hire purchase. Hire purchase means I am paying over a long period. I have not finished paying, but the agreement says that I will be in possession and I will be making installment payments as agreed. If I want

to apply that in official purposes, I only have to exhibit that agreement. Then we also have outright ownership. One purchases and pays for it and transfer of ownership is done. So, if one needs it for official purposes, one can exhibit that.

So, this is like a checklist giving indications to the number of instances that this will be applicable. So, one can tick one box and where it is applicable— If it is not about hire purchase, one can leave it. It is not necessarily required for one to tick it.

Clause 60 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 61 — Application for licence to operate foreign fishing vessel

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan: Mr Speaker, respectfully, if we read clause 61(1),

“A person who intends to operate a foreign fishing vessel shall apply to the Minister for a licence to operate a foreign fishing vessel.”

If we juxtapose this with clause 59(1) which says:

“A person who intends to operate a Ghanaian industrial fishing vessel shall apply in a prescribed form...”

Mr Speaker, if we are applying for a local one, there is that statement that it should be in a prescribed form, but for a foreign one, it does not say so. May we know if there is a reason for that. If not, then we need to repeat the same thing, so that whether foreign or local, there is a prescribed form.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Read clause 61(2).

Mr A. Alhassan: Respectfully, Mr Speaker, clause 61(2) reads:

“An application under subsection (1) shall be in writing and accompanied with the prescribed fee and the following documents.”

Mr Speaker, that still does not say the exact words used in clause 59. Because it can still be in writing, but is it in the prescribed form as used in clause 59.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, there are two different licences; one for local Ghanaians and another for foreigners. We just step up the proof and oversight by the Minister to be sure that they satisfy the conditions under 61(2), for the Minister to satisfy herself then authorise the issuance of the licence. So, it is deliberate and there is nothing wrong with that. So, I pray that we allow the current rendition to stay.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr A. Alhassan: Mr Speaker to buttress my point, if we go back to clause 59(2) which is the local, it still says an application under subsection 1 shall be in writing. So even having said in 59(1) that it should be in prescribed form, we come to 59(2) and it still says “in writing”. So, if we come to clause 61 and we omit —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, your difficulty is that because they have prescribed a form for the locals, they should do same for the foreign ones too.

Mr A. Alhassan: Exactly, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Meanwhile the conditions are not the same. Why do you argue that the locals should be treated equally like the foreigners?

Mr A. Alhassan: Mr Speaker, no it is just to ensure there is consistency in how we apply—Because the form is a form. Whichever information we want to put in the form is up to the Commission. But there should be a prescribed form be it local or foreign.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, I again pray that we allow clause 61 to stay as it is. There are sub-regional and international protocols on these and we have checked other countries and how it is done for foreign vessels. So, this is consistent and I pray that we allow this to stay.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I have been following the argument and I think for the sake of standardisation, I tend to tilt towards my Hon Member from —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Minority Chief Whip, do you want the locals to be subjected to the international standard? That is what we are talking about.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The understanding I have is that one leg has a standardisation, the other has no standardisation. It is firmer with the international standard. Well, if the Chairman is making the argument that it is flowing as a result of best practice, then I will not argue further and yield to him, but maybe the drafters should consult more on it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I understand this to mean that for the locals, they have prescribed a form which simplifies things for them. Do you understand? There is a prescribed form for the locals. So, you are completing a form. But as to whether we can make the law for the internationals to also have a prescribed form, then that particular form must be in conformity with the international or other countries. So, what is the best practice?

Yes, Hon Member?

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah: Thank you Mr Speaker. I think I would tend to agree with my Colleague over there. It is a matter of standardisation. Why would we not standardise it and make everyone have a prescribed form, whether it is foreign or local? Because the moment we leave that room for no prescribed form for foreign, we all know what happens when it is foreign. We know there are a lot of things that happen when it is not a Ghanaian owned. So, I tend to agree with him.

4.12 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then some of the provisions must be deleted.

So, that you do not subject some to a wholly owned Ghanaian company.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we should not belabor this point. We should just let the drafters, in consultation with the Chairman—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will direct the drafters to look at this and tidy it up. Subject to the directive to the drafters to reconcile clauses 61 and 59, I will put the Question on 61.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 61 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 62 is ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 63 — Consideration and grant of fishing licence.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Yes, starting from the Hon Member at the back.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, under clause 63, the provision in sub-clause (2) establishes the Fishing Licence Evaluation Committee and it has listed the composition up to paragraph (e). My difficulty is with sub-clause (2)(f) which reads:

“any other organisation that the Commission may determine”

Mr Speaker, I think that when it comes to the establishment of a Committee in an Act like this, it is important for the determination, as has been made here, to stand. But, if we open it up again to any other organisation that the Commission may determine, I think it is an open space that may create some problem in the future.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, he has a point. The clause 63(2)(f) was deliberately added, taking cognisance of the fact that it is an evolving field and there are new emerging technologies and institutions that have control of this sub-sector. The National Signals Bureau just passed a new law, Ghana Shippers' Authority Act, and with new provisions. So, we thought that it was safer to allow some

caveat that if there is a relevant institution that will contribute to getting a proper and better evaluation, then we should allow the Commission to be able to include that in its evaluation committee. So, I think that they can use it or not based on what institutions are available and can contribute to proper evaluation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the essence of an omnibus clause is to make room for any eventuality. If you remove the omnibus clause and in future, there is the need to include something, then you must come to Parliament and have the provision amended; else, you will not be able to do it. That is why mostly, they use the omnibus clause to give room.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I think there is a difference between establishing a committee and a committee relying on other stakeholders for advice or co-opting them to come and assist in their work. I believe as a House, when we are establishing committees with representation, they should stand as it is. If after some years, based on development and by practice, they can always come back at a later time. But for us to create that open—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you not think that Parliament will be so much inundated if there is no omnibus clause for committees established and for them to use any relevant one that is not mentioned, they will have to come to Parliament and go through the process to have the law amended before they will be able to carry it on?

Yes, Hon Kabiru?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I tend to agree with the current rendition. My proposed amendment was following from that. So, I probably would want to see if I could tie it together with his point, so we consider them together. I was suggesting that while clause 63(2)(f) will remain, we explicitly mention the Ghana Standards Authority. The reason I said I agree with the provision to stand is because I have in my mind that the Ghana Standards Authority is a relevant institution that could be relied on or that could be engaged further in terms of this Committee.

Mr Speaker, this is because they deal with fishing gears and vessels and these has to conform with standard practice and the Ghana Standards Authority is the regulator and the body, so mandated. So, I think that we must, in addition to leaving this omnibus clause or paragraph, state clearly that the Ghana Standards Authority should be part of that particular Committee.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, exactly the reason the omnibus clause is there. We cannot enumerate all of them, so when we get to a stage, we must subsume them under—*[Interruption]*—Yes, we have passed different instruments in respect of standardisation, so it will be catered for under the omnibus. Mr Speaker, I humbly submit.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, before you put the Question, I think the suggestion for an express provision for the Ghana Standards Authority should be there. It is now an Authority, I am told. Then we can still keep clause 63(2) (f) as an omnibus—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am just providing guidance. The guidance I am providing is that by putting the omnibus clause here, it means that this particular list is not exhaustive. That is what it means. So, if in future, there is even—Now, we have the fishing industry nominated by the National Fisheries Association of Ghana (NAFAG). If tomorrow, there is also another association which is not in existence today, and there is the need to bring that particular association into existence, if the omnibus clause is deleted here, it means for them to do it, they would have to come to Parliament for Parliament to include it before they can make use of it. So, to avoid these things, the omnibus clause is there to take care of the concerns being raised. That “A” or “B” should have been included.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I listened to the Chairman, who clearly has taken time to go through the Bill, and he had made a very profound statement. That is an evolving industry; hence, justifying the need for the omnibus clause to be there. However, how does he convince me that an important entity of state, such as the Ghana Standards Authority, will be left out? It cannot be. It is not harmful; let us just put it there and proceed and let us keep the omnibus clause.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let us concede, so that we add to the present list of entities. Let us add the Ghana Standards Authority and maintain the omnibus clause for any future agency, so that we can make progress.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we would have an even number of Committee Members.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, you are right, so let us leave it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is the very reason the omnibus clause is there.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Otherwise, Mr Speaker, it will affect the structure—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Normally, for Board Committees, it is odd numbers.

Mr Dafeamekpor: It will affect the structure of the provision.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it will affect the structure.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, if you look at the provision well, you would realise that there are some people mentioned who could have easily fallen under the “other relevant stakeholders”. It is for good reason they are mentioned here specifically. We are equally arguing that the mandate of the Ghana Standards Authority is so obvious, in respect of this matter, that we would categorise them under “other relevant authorities”. That

is the problem we have with leaving it at “other relevant authorities”.

4.22 p.m.

Other than that the clause could have just read, “...other relevant authorities” and we will leave it to the implementers, but where it is so obvious that a certain authority has mandate over certain matters and those matters are being discussed, without opportunity for that institution to be represented. And to do their work as required by law, I think this Parliament cannot gloss over that fact and we should not implement this law. We can go and address the issue about the even numbers. That one can be addressed later. But the representation —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, it will have to be addressed here.

Dr Mahama: We can address that by looking — if I make my points so strongly, you would include them to make it even but for the purpose of Ghana Standards Authority, Mr Speaker, I humbly submit that we must have it expressed in this particular Act.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is the sense of the House?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, these are matters of policy. So, in the event that the Ministry is of the view that they invite a Rep from Ghana Standards Authority to participate in the Committee, they will do so. Otherwise, then we are affecting the numerical

strength of the Committee, Mr Speaker. It will affect the structure if we insist. At Consideration, you may have strong views, but when the sponsors of the Bill have the opinion that what they brought to the House sufficiently deals with the existing situation, you are minded to go with them. So, Mr Speaker —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the rule and the practice is that if you feel strong about it, then move an amendment and let me put a question on the amendment for the House to take a decision.

Dr Mahama: So, Mr Speaker, insertion of a new paragraph after (e),

“the Ghana Standards Authority not below the rank of a Deputy Director, nominated by the Director-General of the Ghana Standards Authority”.

I so move, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am first putting the question on the amendment proposed by Dr Mahama.

Question put and amendment negated.

Clause 63 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 64 — Refusal of application for fishing licence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Yes?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Clause 64(1) is indicating that “the Minister or the Commission, where appropriate, shall refuse an application for fishing licence under this Act”.

Mr Speaker, I have read the conditions under which the refusal will be placed. But when you go to 63(3), it talks about the Committee making recommendations to the Minister through the Executive Director for the grant of the relevant licence. So, my difficulty is leaving the refusal. If the Commission makes a recommendation, it is for the Minister to make a decision. But where we are now creating a situation where the Minister or the Commission is to make a determination for refusal without clearly determining the boundaries upon which the Commission will make that refusal against that of the Minister. So, if at least there can be some clarification before I move my proposal.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The rendition says:

“The Minister or the Commission, where appropriate, shall refuse an application for a fishing licence under this Act, or Regulations made under this Act if the applicant

- (a) fails to submit a complete application;
- (b) submits false or misleading information;
- (c) fails to attach any document required; or
- (d) fails to pay the prescribed fee”.

So, the rendition did not end there. You have to read it as a whole. So, the circumstances based on which the Commission or the Minister can do that are spelt out in the law.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for your guidance. But I have read the document as a whole and it is on that basis I try to make that submission. And my submission, which I still think is relevant for the House to consider, is to the extent that when it comes to the decision to refuse the application, is it the position that that refusal is to the Minister or to the Commission? This is because where you have indicated the basis for refusal and you say the mandate of the Commission is to make recommendation, that is where I have a difficulty. I do not know if the Chairman of the Committee understands.

So, I am of the respectful view that that power to determine the refusal should be made clear. If it is the Minister that should refuse or the Commission or the Committee. That is the position I want us to look at.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, let us look at the process. The

Commission recommends to the Minister to approve. Now before the Commission would recommend, it is based on certain requirements. So, if at the level of the Commission, you did not meet the requirements, why is there a need for the Commission to even be recommending to the Minister? So, at that particular stage, that can be a refusal. There can be a refusal appropriately at that level. So, by that, the Commission is not going to recommend to the Minister. You have been refused a licence at that level.

Now the second scenario is where the Commission recommends to the Minister, but the Minister feels that he needs additional information to be able to approve the licence because the recommendation of the Commission is not binding on the Minister; it is a recommendation. So, when you do not meet that particular requirement, appropriately, the Minister can also refuse you at that level. So, the word “appropriately” is trying to cure the instances where you can be refused. That is the understanding that I have gathered.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I think with that explanation, it makes it easier to proceed. On that note, I yield. I think Mr Speaker should be heading towards the Court of Appeal for interpretation — *[Laughter]*—

4.32 p.m.

On that note, I yield. I think Mr Speaker should be heading towards the Court of Appeal for interpretation— *[Laughter]*—

[Pause]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: All right, let us make progress.

Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan: Mr Speaker, reading clause 64, it looks like no room is given for the Minister to at least give some consideration to the applicant to go and make an amendment to their application. Once the application is seen to be incomplete, it is rejected outright. That would be too harsh.

Mr Speaker, I have just referred to the Minerals and Mining Act, and section 42 of the Act gives that room to the Minister. With your permission, I read.

“Rejection of application for a mining lease.

The Minister shall not reject an application for a mining lease made under this Act.

(a) Unless the concerns of the Minister have been made in writing to the applicant and the applicant has been given an opportunity to make appropriate amendment to the application.”

So, Mr Speaker, my argument is that there should be an opportunity given to the applicant to go and make an amendment to their application. Otherwise, to just say that because his application is incomplete, it is thrown out outrightly, I think that would be too harsh. And it would be a ground for some chaos.

So, Mr Speaker, I humbly submit that we do an insertion into 64 to make room for some opportunity—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what is your proposed amendment?

Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan: Mr Speaker, I was just trying to copy what has been said here. Maybe if we can *insert* a clause 64(3) to read,

“The Minister shall not reject an application for a fishing licence made under this Act unless the concerns of the Minister have been conveyed in writing to the applicant, and the applicant has been given an opportunity to make appropriate amendments to the application.”

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, I think his concern is actually captured exactly in 64(2), which reads,

“Where an application is refused, the Commission or the Minister, where appropriate, shall, within seven working days, communicate the decision in writing to the applicant, stating the reasons for the refusal.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee, is there not a grievance procedure in the Law?

Dr Jasaw: There is a grievance procedure.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Member, if there is a grievance procedure, would your concern not be addressed under the grievance procedure?

Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan: Maybe we may have to wait and get to that portion to see if it is captured. Otherwise, I was thinking this would have been the best place to put it, respectfully.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, just a short comment on what is submitted. My respectful view is that it will be difficult, given the circumstances, under which the Minister or the Commission may refuse, particularly, when we come to 64(1b), submit false or misleading information. Why would we want the person to go back and remedy that and come back?

So, it is important that, on the basis of refusal, we leave it as it is. And if the person is refused and it is communicated to them, it is their burden to remedy and reapply, since the application process is clearly stated. That is my respectful view.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are to submit documents A, B, C, and D, based on which I will grant you a licence. You choose to submit incomplete documents, and you are asking me to tell you that the document that you have submitted is incomplete.

So, go and bring the document. Why would you then give me incomplete documents, requesting that I make a decision based on them? And if a decision is taken based on your document and you think my decision is not proper, then if you are aggrieved, the remedies are available for you.

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah: Mr Speaker, respectfully, people can present documents that are incomplete or false unknowingly. There can be situations where people unknowingly present certain documents. So, on that note, I think that we should have a grievance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you brought the document to me, which is a false document. Then you said you produced a false document unknowingly? So, then you will be caught by the fact that ignorance of the law will not avail you.

Clauses 64 and 65 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 66, Chairman of the Committee?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, clause 66(1) states that

“The fishing licence issued under this Act is valid for a period of one year or a lesser period specified in the licence.”

I am having difficulty with why we would give a licence period of one year, which is specific in the Act, and say that or a lesser period specified under the licence. Is it saying that we have the power to give one year and at another period, the power to give less than one year? And what are the circumstances of that?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Member, assuming you are a member of the Bar, the Bar licence is for a period of

one year, starting from January to December. Then, in June, you are requesting for a licence. Do you expect to be given a one-year licence or less than a year?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I think that is far-fetched, respectfully. No, we have different licences, and if it is a calendar year, then that should be stated. But if we say one year, depending on my year of application, if I apply in March, the license is valid for one year. We have had those licences issued. So, it is important if we say the licence is one year and it is a calendar year, then we are guided.

But in many instances, when licences are issued, including whether it is whatever institution, it runs beyond a calendar year. Respectfully submitted, Mr Speaker.

Prof Ayensu-Danquah: Mr Speaker, I think I agree with my Colleague here, because the question now would be under what circumstances will we grant a licence valid for the whole year, and what other circumstances will we grant the licence in a lesser period? What are the circumstances that one would get one that is six months and the other one that is a year? It is not very clear. So, I guess the Chairman of the Committee has to clarify that.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, as you indicated, people come and pass through the process at different times of the year. The intention is that the licence is granted from January to December. However, if one comes midway or any

time between that period and apply for the period, it still ends in December. So, it will be less than one year in that specific case and this is how we want it to stand.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, I think you are not convinced.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am only worried about the rendition. Of course, I understand, if it is for a period —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But look clause 66(3).

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: That is so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member,

“A fishing licence shall be renewed annually...”

What is the meaning of “annually”?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: So, Mr Speaker, I think, as I indicated, it is fine based on the explanation. These are the information that guides interpretation to these legislations. So, if we leave it like this and it becomes a subject for litigation, it is always important that the courts are guided by the discussions that happen on the Floor. So I think it is important that guidance is provided that, the licence period is from January to December. But it will be appropriate if it is referred to the drafting team, to draft it in such a way that it will be much clearer than we see today.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 66 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 67 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 68 — Application for licence to operate inland artisanal fishing vessel

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Yes, Dr Mahama?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, at 68(1), I propose that we *delete* “a designated office of the”, so that it shall read:

“A person who intends to operate an inland artisanal fishing vessel shall apply to the Commission...”

Mr Speaker, the regulations that they are going to put out will flesh out the nitty-gritty to be consistent with what has been provided by way of application. Making it, applying to the Commission, will not be so fertile to the Bill. So that the regulation would then designate—If there are district offices of the Commission, then one could then apply

to that. But if we say designated office, here, it is not clear. Secondly, if we leave it at “the Commission”, it is consistent with the mood of application.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the mischief that we are curing here is that if we delete “designated office” and you say “to the Commission”, then applications are to go to the Commission’s designated office. I think there was an authority regarding service of a process where we are supposed to serve the process on entities like this. But if the law says that the Commission itself can designate office where you can send the application, if it is a district office that is designated closer to you, then you can take the application to that designated office.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the problem is that we are assuming that—and as the law provides—there will be district offices. But there will be instances—Even in this same Act, we have not mentioned “designated offices”. We say, “to the Commission”, mindful of the fact that the Commission is the ultimate responsibility.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, do you not think that the framers of the law are of the view that if the Commission is let us say, Parliament, Parliament can designate Accra International Conference Centre (AICC) where the applications are to be sent and if that is done, is it wrong?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, absolutely not wrong, but I am saying that this will be fleshed out in the regulation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Because at the end of the day, it allows —If you come to the Regulation, Regulation is not supposed to be inconsistent to the parent Act. So, it is only when the parent Act signifies that the Commission may designate, then the Regulation can come to beef up that it can be sent to district number 1,2,3 or 4. But if strictly, the law says “the Commission”, you cannot make regulation now to say it should be elsewhere. So, this is not fatal in the law.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I yield.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clauses 68 and 69 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 70 — Validity and renewal of licence to operate inland artisanal fishing vessel.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Yes, Dr Mahama?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I propose that in 70(3), we *insert* “by Regulation” after “may”, so that it would read:

“The Commission may, by Regulation, prescribe the requirement

for the renewal of licence to operate an inland artisanal fishing vessel.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it is for the consideration of the House.

Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, it is not harmful and so I am amenable to it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I have a problem with that particular rendition. The Act is giving the power to the Commission directly to prescribe the requirement for renewal of licences to operate an inland artisanal fishing vessel. Hon Members, if you said the Commission should be by Regulation, then it means until and unless the Regulation is brought in this House and passed under Article 11(7), the Commission cannot issue the licence. So, to introduce a regulation there, that is a hardship and that is a confusion that will be causing.

4.52 p.m.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I understand the fact that we do not impose a burden on the Commission in their work, but it is not a mandatory provision that they should prescribe. The framers of this particular provision said “may” and if we have to prescribe, there must be an order regulating how these prescriptions are going to be made. If it is done without a subsidiary law moderating or guiding how this prescription is going to be made, Mr Speaker, I feel like it is going to be done haphazardly and I was of the view that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No. Hon Member, look at Article 296 of the Constitution. Where discretionary power is given in instances of this nature, the Constitution spells out how that discretionary power is supposed to be prescribed.

Normally, when we make laws, like in this case, we say, “the Commission may, within 12 months, make a Regulation”. Now, when we say, “the Commission may by Regulation, prescribe the requirement”, by this law, we are saying that until the Regulation is ready, if there is the need to prescribe a requirement, they cannot do it until the regulation is ready.

However, when you leave it like this, that “the Commission may prescribe the requirement”, they can even do it by a Regulation, but the aspect that we should look at is that, once you put the Regulation there, unless it is a Regulation, they cannot. If the Regulation is not here, they may do it by a Regulation.

Dr Mahama: All right, thank you very much. Mr Speaker, I am guided; Articles 296 and 23 of the Constitution have given me the cue. But, Mr Speaker, I just hope my fear would be addressed in the implementation because the fear is that we know Regulation provides the vehicle under which this will be done. So, if we say they may do it by Regulation or they may do it without Regulation, without Regulation is where my fear is. If we think that it will not be characterised by the whims and caprices of the administrative Authority—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What we should take into consideration is that these are existing practices. This law comes to replace the existing one and licencing regimes are already in place. Therefore, if we make this law and tie it down to a Regulation, then all licences that will be issued after the passage of this law must wait and abide by the passage of the Regulation. That one will be very mischievous.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I yield. I am swayed by the last bit of your explanation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Clause 70 is ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 71 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 72 — Prohibition of fishing in coastal waters without a licence.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it is for the consideration of the House.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, clause 72(c), states that:

“issued with a licence for the purpose by the Commission in collaboration with the relevant District Assembly.”

I beg to move that we *delete* “in collaboration with the relevant District Assembly” because this is about licence renewal or approval and it is the mandate of the Commission to do that. If the Commission is to do that with or without the collaboration of the District Assembly therein, I think it is up to the Commission, but where we have said,

“(a) constructed in accordance with specifications prescribed by the Commission; and

(b) registered with the Commission; and

(c) issued with a licence for the purpose by the Commission,”

I think that should end there, rather than bringing in “in collaboration with the relevant District Assembly”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, take your argument again, so that you can carry all of us along.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am saying that clause 72 talks about “Prohibition of fishing in coastal waters without a licence” and it says that:

“72. A person shall not operate a marine artisanal fishing vessel in the coastal waters of the country unless, the marine artisanal fishing vessel is

(a) constructed in accordance with specifications prescribed by the Commission; and

(b) registered with the Commission; and

(c) issued with a licence for the purpose by the Commission...”

I do not see why we should include, “in collaboration with the relevant District Assembly”, so I propose that we *delete* it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, we should *delete* “in collaboration with relevant District Assembly”? Is that your proposal?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: That is so, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The Hon Member makes a very good point. However, I totally disagree with him. For instance, if one wants to analyse the work of the Minerals Commission, the granting of licence for the exploration of sand winning, specific to sand winning, what I know is that the granting of the licence is done in collaboration with the district assemblies. Why? Because that is where the action is.

If his argument is that the District should flow from (a), so that it is consistent—If it should start from (a), so that the district or the municipal assemblies will flow from (a) all the way to (c), I can understand him, but if it is the case that we should *delete* entirely the “District Assembly”, I tend not to share that argument.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Member, your argument is that the Commission will sit at the head office and issue the licences without recourse to the district concerned and now, the law is imposing an obligation on them. These are security issues and the District Security Council (DISEC) would have to be in the picture.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, these are laws, so if we say “in collaboration with the relevant District Assembly”, what constitutes collaboration?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This is not the first time things are being done in collaboration with others.

Mr Anthony Mmieh: Mr Speaker, I disagree with the Hon Member for Effia Constituency for the reason that this is similar to licences issued to miners who work within the various districts. The districts play a very important role as far as licencing, supervision, *et cetera*. One cannot just walk into a district from Greater Accra or from the city to say that they are going to conduct business within a district without the involvement of the district and even the traditional authorities. So, I believe it should be maintained as it is.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: That is right. I think that what the drafters can do is that there are similar legislations that capture or couch the language so well—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is licence; it will not be operated. It is issued in collaboration with the district.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Whether it is collaboration or consultation, I think the drafters can guide us.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you want the rendition to be “in consultation”?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes.

5.02 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I think it should be in collaboration, because the district may even be issuing you a business operating licence. They may issue a business operating licence at the district level. So, that cannot be in consultation, but they are involved in the process. So, it should rather be “in collaboration”.

Hon Members, let us go back to clause 4(1) (o) of the Bill, under “functions of the Commission”. It states clearly that:

“collaborate with the District Assemblies, fishing communities and other stakeholders to ensure the enforcement of the laws on fisheries and aquaculture;”

So, now we are saying that we should take out the district assemblies when it comes to the issue of licence. They should not collaborate with them, because this is part of their functions.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, when I ask for its deletion, it did not mean that collaboration cannot happen, particularly when you have referenced clause 4(1) (o). So, for the pleasure of the

House and for purposes of emphasis, we want to still repeat it there, but we have not seen that collaboration espoused in other licencing regimes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Member, how will you enforce the prohibitions?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, as I said, that was my view, so let me drop it for us to make room.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: So, what are we going by? Are we going by what is existing? “In collaboration”?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He said he has dropped it.

Clause 72 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 73 to 76 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 77 — Record of licences.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment? Yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, you are senior to me in this matter. I believe the phrase we use is “register of licences”. We use the register which itemises all the licences issued and not

“record”. I raised it with the drafters when we met but I am surprised that it survived.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, it makes a lot of sense. I yield. So, we could amend this to read as “Register of licences”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, propose an amendment.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, head note, “Record of licences” should read “Register of licences”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, consequentially in the clause.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It should read “Register of licences” instead of “Record of licences”. Consequentially, I direct the drafters to clean it up in the provisions of the Bill.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 77 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 78 — Employment of citizens.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: I recall that during the discussion with the stakeholders, we were told that they would look at the framing “employment of citizens”. These days, we employ “local content provision”, so we are hoping that they would have tidied it to reflect “local content provision” and not “employment of citizens”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, if you look at clause 78(1), it is neater. Because though it is talking about local content, it is with specific reference to citizens.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I yield.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any other concerns?

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Anthony Mmieh: Mr Speaker, I seek your guidance on the heading for clause 78. It says “Employment of citizens”. I think it is a little bit vague. Unfortunately, when we go to clause 170, it does not also define who a citizen is. We would have to throw more light on the heading.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Member, a citizen is defined by the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana. So, we cannot be defining it in this law; it is clear.

Mr Mmieh: But Mr Speaker, in the context of this law, a citizen has not been defined. I know it is clearly defined in —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why I am saying that in the context of this law, the definition of a citizen is not different from what is contained in our Constitution.

Mr Mmieh: For the avoidance of doubt, can we get some clarity on it?

5.12 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, if it is not a term of art, it has been defined, and we all know whom a citizen is. We cannot be putting that elaborate constitutional definition of citizens into these provisions. I believe any ordinary Ghanaian would know the meaning of a citizen.

Clause 78 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 79 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 80 — Designation of aquaculture development zone.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Mahama.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, clause 80, subclause (1), paragraph (a), *delete* “increase the development of” and *insert* “develop” so that it will read: “attract, promote or develop aquaculture establishment in areas which are particularly suitable for aquaculture.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, we *delete* “increase” and *insert* what?

Dr Mahama: “Increase the development of” and replace that with “develop”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It cannot be “develop the development”?

Dr Mahama: No. Mr Speaker, delete “increase the development of” and replace it with “develop”. Because when you say increase the development of one is so difficult to grasp. We do not even know what that means. But if you just replace it with “develop”, it makes it tidier and simpler to understand. And I think that, yes— “attract, promote or develop aquaculture establishment in areas which are particularly suitable for aquaculture”.

Mr Speaker, I so move.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, it sounds compelling. I am tempted to yield to him. If there are no other considerations that would change me. I think it is fine. We can go with it.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Let me counter Hon Kabiru by saying, instead of changing “increase”, if we introduce “enhance”, it gives more effect to the

“development”. “To attract, promote or enhance the development of aquaculture”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Dr Mahama, do we use the word, “enhance”?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I think that we can go with “enhance development”. But the “increase the development” was not appropriate. And I will defer to that particular suggestion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Because the understanding is that there is a development of aquaculture but we need to enhance that development. So, the rendition will be “attract, promote or enhance the development of aquaculture establishment in areas which are particularly suitable for aquaculture.”

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Now, Clause 80 still under consideration?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am proposing a new paragraph after 80(1)(f). We shall — a new clause. I mean, it is a new paragraph. Subclause. Maybe it is a new subclause (g), “conserve aquaculture resources”.

Mr Speaker, I am making this suggestion because the essence of aquaculture development zone, is about conservation, about sustainable use of the resources. But looking through, that does not come out clearly. So, if we have such a paragraph.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, propose a rendition.

Dr Mahama: So, new subclause (g) after (f) — “conserve aquaculture resources”.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I know my Colleague has paid good attention. I am trying to get the distinction between conservation of aquaculture and protection of aquaculture. Because, it is the same. (e) is “protect aquaculture development”. And he is proposing a subclause as “conserve”.

I think it is —

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, conservation is a term of art.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, are you proposing that instead of saying protect aquaculture in (e), we use the word conservation?

Dr Mahama: Yes, but aquaculture development is different from aquaculture resources. These are two different things. And if we do not get that distinction also right, we may be saying something different.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you are saying they should conserve aquaculture resources.

Hon Members, I am inclined to put a Question and it is carried. So, I will then put the Question on the entire—

Yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, if we may get his boss to withdraw his counter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, that is not a counter proposal. He feels that the amendment that he proposed is taken care of by (e). So, he did not propose any amendment. So, the amendment proposed that I am going to put the Question on is —

Mr Dafeamekpor: Let us take it, I am in agreement.

Prof Hamza Adam: Mr Speaker, I agree with Dr Mahama's position that we should introduce conservation.

However—

Prof Adam: I am of the view that we can combine it with protect. So, it can read as protect and conserve.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: On the floor, there is an indication that conservation of aquaculture resources is different from protection of aquaculture development. So, why are you taking us back?

I am putting the question on Dr Mahama's proposed amendment.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The amendment is carried. There will be a new paragraph, sub-paragraph (g) to take care of the proposed amendment.

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I want to propose an insertion, an addition of the letter “and” on clause 2(a) to come after “economic”, so that it will read, the 2(a) will read—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do we have clause 2(m)?

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: (a).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 2(a).

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: Yes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: All right.

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: So, that the clause will read, “have regard to the scientific, social, economic and environmental impact and other relevant considerations”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, are they not referring to economic, environmental impact as one thing? Or they are referring to social, economic and environmental impact?

Let me seek clarification from the Chairman of the Committee.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, I think what we rather need is to introduce comma, so it is a drafting thing, after “economic”, “social, economic, environmental impact and other...”.

So, we do not need to double —

5.22 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Because if you put “and” there, there is “and” after “impact”. So, the proposed amendment is after “economic” put “,”.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Yes, Dr Kabiru Mahama?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am trying to get one — 80(4). It reads; “The Minister may by notice in the *Gazette*,

Mr Speaker, I need guidance from you and the Majority Chief Whip on this matter because we have had previous — Because they said “The Minister shall by notice in the *Gazette*” and it stops there. I was thinking if we may add the issue of reasonable notice or publicity. Because this is a *Gazette* of areas that they are going to determine as development zones and to *gazette* it without a bit about notice or publication in the dailies like we provide. I was just thinking if we can—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, *Gazette* notification is a term of art. So, you do not tinker with that. You do not qualify it. No, so, the phrase is saying the Minister may by notice in the *Gazette*. So, once the notice appears in the *gazette*, he is able to do (a) and (b).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kabiru Mahama, in this country, if our boundaries are altered, where do you give the notice?

So, what is wrong with this provision?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the issue is not about the problem with the *Gazette*. I was just thinking that notice of same. Though the *Gazette* is notice, we have five in the previous clause—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Kabiru Mahama, if a Bill is going to be introduced, where do you put the notice?

Dr Mahama: In the *Gazette*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, that notice that we refer to is different from this particular notice. Because the other notice is about some information or publicities. But this one is talking about alteration of the boundary. So, when the boundaries are altered, it is the *Gazette*.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 80 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill

Clause 81 — Conduct of aquaculture in aquaculture development zone.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Clause 81 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 82 — Requirement for registration of aquaculture holding facility.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Clause 82 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 83 — Requirement for registration and licencing of commercial aquaculture establishment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Clause 83 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 84 — Qualification to install or operate an aquaculture establishment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Clause 84 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, before we proceed, I would like to remind Colleagues that we are scheduled to Sit tomorrow, which is out of the ordinary because tomorrow is Saturday. So, ordinarily, we had agreed to stop at clause 80, but we want to proceed further and rather exit at clause 90. I want to plead with my Colleagues that we should exit at clause 90 so that we can conserve. We just used the word conservation. *[Laughter]* We can conserve some strength for tomorrow's Sitting. I plead with you. We have helped you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I appreciate the support from our Brothers and Sisters in this matter. But this is not an ordinary Bill. This is a Bill that we are taking under a certificate of urgency. There is some urgency to meeting some deadlines, and I appreciate all that you are doing with us. Let me plead— Mr Speaker, so let us do up to clause 100.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will take the Bill to clause 100; it is four leaflets.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we will try to exit at clause 100 even though it is difficult, we will try to meet you midway. However, you know what to do. Mr Speaker, he knows what to do. He should do the needful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, on this note, I have heard you loud and clear. *[Laughter]*

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I request from my Brother to provide me with the needful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, clause 85.

Clause 85 — Application for an aquaculture licence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. The Committee does not have an advertised amendment. Any proposed amendment?

Clause 85 is ordered to stand as part of the Bill.

Clause 86 — Introduction and transfer of aquatic organisms.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Clause 86 is ordered to stand as part of the Bill.

Clause 87 — Monitoring and inspection of aquaculture establishment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment to Clause 87?

Clause 87 is ordered to stand as part of the Bill.

Clause 88 — Report of disease or harmful organism.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Clause 88 is ordered to stand as part of the Bill.

Clause 89 — Water monitoring system.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Clause 89 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 90 — Import and export of live aquatic organism.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

5.32 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of House. Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, under clause 90 (1), it says:

“(1) A person shall not, without approval of the Commission,

(a) import a live aquatic organism...”

My difficulty is the application for approval of that process. It is not clearly stated and I believe that we need to look at that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There was a clause that gave the discretion to the Commission to prescribe and they are saying that the prescription should be by Regulations, so that they can use that particular provision—

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: So, the intendment is that it may come under—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, they can also prescribe.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Very well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further concerns?

Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo: Mr Speaker, please, I want to take you back to clause 89(2)(b).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Member, we can only do it during the Second Consideration Stage.

Mr Aidoo: Mr Speaker, it is a mistake.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We can only do it at the Second Consideration Stage. That is the procedure.

Mr Aidoo: All right.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, I will put the Question.

Clauses 90 and 91 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 92 — Aquaculture waste.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, any proposed amendment?

Yes, Dr Kabiru, you have the floor.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I beg to move that clause 92(2), *delete* “section 113” and *insert* “section 114”.

Mr Speaker, it is in section 114 that compliant notice is dealt with under the Act.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will direct the draftspersons to do the proper cross-referencing. Any further issue?

Clause 92 to 95 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 96 — Penalty for failure to comply with aquaculture requirements

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, from my observation on penalties, I have not seen any custodial sentences being proposed in this Bill. May I be guided by the Chairman of the Committee before I make a proposal on why we are not making provision for custodial sentences for this?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, it is a social economic event, so we think that there are ways of resolving and punishing people where it applies and there is a criminal code in there.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, let me guide you. These are administrative penalties and, mostly, failure to pay administrative penalties have a mode of recovering same. So, these are not the penalties where the sanctions should be by imprisonment or fine. These are not criminal offences, *per se*, that the punishment is by way of a fine. These are penalties for non-compliance.

Clause 96 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 97 — Registration of fish processing and storage establishment.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendments?

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Alhassan Umar: Mr Speaker, I want to suggest that we cannot regulate it in a way that citizens cannot or will be prohibited to do small scale fishing, not fish *galamsey*—[*Laughter*—fish farming. In agriculture—[*Interruption*—No, the regulations are too much. In clause 97(1), it says:

“A person shall not operate a micro fish processing or storage establishment unless that person...”

When we put such barriers, we are regulating them. No, I mean, everything in this document says that nobody can do anything, even small fish farming. Everything in this document is regulating and putting people in some box. We cannot do that. We cannot continue to regulate and want people to be entrepreneurs, inventors and innovators. We cannot do that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if your argument is anything to go by, why are you regulating drivers? [*Laughter*]

Mr Umar: Mr Speaker, the Leader wants to take over from me.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I appreciate what he is saying because I come from a largely fishing constituency. I will use the Regulation to indicate the levels and the extent. So, when we mean “micro”, we will define it and tell people the scale that it will be captured within it. So, he should be assured that when the Regulations come—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But, Hon Member, the provision says:

“(1) A person shall not operate a micro fish processing or storage establishment unless that person

- (a) is registered by the Commission;
- (b) has complied with this Act, Regulations made under this Act and any other relevant enactment; and
- (c) has complied with any other conditions prescribed by the Commission.

(2) An application for the registration of a micro...”

So, are we saying because it is micro, the Commission should not even prescribe conditions?

5.32 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of House. Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, under clause 90(1), it says:

“(1) A person shall not, without approval of the Commission,

(b) import a live aquatic organism...”

My difficulty is the application for approval of that process. It is not clearly stated and I believe that we need to look at that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There was a clause that gave the discretion to the Commission to prescribe and they are saying that the prescription should be by Regulations, so that they can use that particular provision—

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: So, the intendment is that it may come under—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, they can also prescribe.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Very well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further concerns?

Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo: Mr Speaker, please, I want to take you back to clause 89(2)(b).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Member, we can only do it during the Second Consideration Stage.

Mr Aidoo: Mr Speaker, it is a mistake.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We can only do it at the Second Consideration Stage. That is the procedure.

Mr Aidoo: All right.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, I will put the Question.

Clauses 90 and 91 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 92 — Aquaculture waste.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, any proposed amendment?

Yes, Dr Kabiru, you have the floor.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I beg to move that clause 92(2), *delete* “section 113” and *insert* “section 114”.

Mr Speaker, it is in section 114 that compliant notice is dealt with under the Act.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will direct the draftspersons to do the proper cross-referencing. Any further issue?

Clause 92 to 95 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 96 — Penalty for failure to comply with aquaculture requirements.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, from my observation on penalties, I have not seen any custodial sentences being proposed in this Bill. May I be guided by the Chairman of the Committee before I make a proposal on why we are not making provision for custodial sentences for this?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, it is a social economic event, so we think that there are ways of resolving and punishing people where it applies and there is a criminal code in there.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, let me guide you. These are administrative penalties and, mostly, failure to pay administrative penalties have a mode of recovering same. So, these are not the penalties where the sanctions should be by imprisonment or fine. These are not criminal offences, *per se*, that the punishment is by way of a fine. These are penalties for non-compliance.

Clause 96 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 97 — Registration of fish processing and storage establishment.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendments?

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Alhassan Umar: Mr Speaker, I want to suggest that we cannot regulate it in a way that citizens cannot or will be prohibited to do small scale fishing, not fish *galamsey*—[Laughter]—fish farming. In agriculture—[Interruption]—No, the regulations are too much. In clause 97(1), it says:

“A person shall not operate a micro fish processing or storage establishment unless that person...”

When we put such barriers, we are regulating them. No, I mean, everything in this document says that nobody can do anything, even small fish farming. Everything in this document is regulating and putting people in some box. We cannot do that. We cannot continue to regulate and want people to be entrepreneurs, inventors and innovators. We cannot do that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if your argument is anything to go by, why are you regulating drivers? [Laughter]

Mr Umar: Mr Speaker, the Leader wants to take over from me.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I appreciate what he is saying because I come from a largely fishing constituency. I will use the Regulation to indicate the levels and the extent. So, when we mean

“micro”, we will define it and tell people the scale that it will be captured within it. So, he should be assured that when the Regulations come—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But, Hon Member, the provision says:

“(1) A person shall not operate a micro fish processing or storage establishment unless that person

(a) is registered by the Commission;

(b) has complied with this Act, Regulations made under this Act and any other relevant enactment; and

(c) has complied with any other conditions prescribed by the Commission.

(2) An application for the registration of a micro...”

5.42 p.m.

So, are we saying because it is micro, the Commission should not even prescribe conditions?

Clause 97 to 99 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 100 — Qualification for permit to import fish, fishery products, and aquaculture products.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, we have no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Yes, Hon Asamoah?

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, clause 99 talks about permits; then clause 100 talks about registration certificates. We want the Chairman of the Committee to give some clarity here because many a time, people get confused and they tend to use the permit interchangeably with the certificate. If not, then I think we should use that same term throughout and especially, when you go to the Interpretation clause, there is no definition for permit, neither do we have definition for certificate here as part of the interpretation. So, if the Chairman can explain a little bit further on what they mean by the registration certificate by the Commission, not the Companies Act, 2019 (Act 992), but by the Commission and the permit as stated in clause 99.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Dr Jasaw: Well, Mr Speaker, I think that is self-explanatory. The Companies Act is very clear on the register of companies and what the requirements are and who qualifies. Registering with the Commission allows the register of the Commission to capture the details and it has an elaborate criterion on what information is required by such importers of fishery or fishery products. Then there are fees that attracts as well. So, these are quite self-explanatory processes. I do not know if that satisfies him.

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, here, it is a little bit unclear as to one needing either a permit to operate or import because it is dealing with importation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are you talking about clause 100?

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, yes, clause 100. Because I am taking import from clause 99. Clause 99 talks about one needing a permit from the Commission to import and it is also talking about needing a certificate from the Commission to import.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, my understanding is that you would be permitted to do an act. For you to be permitted to do an act, you must be qualified and clause 100 is just setting out the qualification requirements. For instance, for you to come to Parliament, you must be qualified to be elected as a Member of Parliament. It is upon satisfying the qualification requirements that you can stand and be voted for to come to Parliament. So, you must satisfy the requirements, which is the qualification, for you to be granted permit to engage in the fish and fishery products.

Hon Asamoah, is that clear?

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, since this is —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Because that is what clause 100 is talking about.

Dr Asamoah: Yes, Mr Speaker, I know we will be ending at 100 today. But

if you look at clauses 99, 100 and 101, these are issues that should be expressed in the regulations but not the Act because these can be updated from time to time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There is a general principle of law. When you sit in meeting of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation, the cardinal question that guides the Committee is whether what is contained in the Regulation is emanating from the parent Act. Once it is not emanating from the parent Act, you cannot do it. You have to satisfy that condition first, before you go further to look at constitutional issues in the passage of a Subsidiary Legislation.

So, the view being expressed that it should not be in the parent Act, but it should be in the Regulation, it is the parent Act that will be the enabling Act to the Regulations. So, when you take it out from the parent Act, what will be the basis of you putting it in the Regulation? So, the Regulation is just to give effect to the provisions of the parent Act. So, if the provision is not here, how do you give effect to it in the Regulation?

So, Hon Members, I have realised that some Members really want to involve themselves in the legislative work. I would advise, at this point, that, sometimes, when the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation is sitting, you join them and pick it up from there.

After reading Article 11, particularly Article 11(7) of the Constitution, you will get the clear picture there. When they are raising the questions that you want to do “A”, show me by the parent

Act, whether you can do it, then you will realise that most of the things contained in the parent Act here should be in the law.

Any further issue about section 100?

Clause 100 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have come to the end of Consideration Stage of Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025 for today.

Hon Members, I use the opportunity to thank you very much for your endurance and I will ask the Whips to take note of those fresh Members who are expressing interest in the legislative work. So that when it comes to offering training outside the jurisdiction of the country, those people should be part of that particular programme—*[Hear! Hear!]*—So, the Whips at both Sides, please, take note.

5.52 p.m.

That is the only way we can develop interest, so that more Members will grasp the rules of drafting and this House will be making very good laws. *[Hear! Hear!]*

So, I encourage you to keep it up. So, the Whips, it is over to you. You should make the proposal accordingly and I will take it up with Mr Speaker.

Ms Shirley Kyei: Small father oo father! *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I heard someone say quietly “small father”. Mr Speaker, you are not a small father; in fact, you are a big deputy father. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: More so, you have been informed that in the absence of the Speaker, I am acting as a Speaker. **[Some Hon Members:** Father oo Father!]

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, I would like to adopt the rendition by the Majority Chief Whip and rectify the designation I gave you accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Ms Kyei: Father, oh father! *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if I am the father oo father, then the Speaker is grandfather, oh grandfather! — *[Laughter]*—because he is my father. So, if the son has become the father, then the father of the son must become grandfather, oh grandfather! Yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we do not know how the father will react, so we will say “deputy father, oo deputy father!”. *[Laughter]*

That was on a lighter note. On a more serious note, we agree with you that like before, it took very few Members to show commitment and participate in this process, and this is actually the core mandate of all of us gathered in here. Mr

Speaker, myself, learning under your feet in 2017, did not get here by accident. So, like Mr Speaker said, it takes works like this to exhibit one's industry. And we will be shocked that our coming back will be easy. This is what our constituents watch and see our participation. So, we thank Members who show this level of commitment. Mr Speaker, we will do the needful.

So, Mr Speaker, that being said, I want to move that in the absence of—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I think we have spent more than five hours.

Mr Dafeamekpor: So, entirely, we are in your hands.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Truly, I have benefited from it. When they spotted me at the corner there, I was part of the people who studied legislative drafting at Cavendish University. We were 10. When we came back, we had to transform the system, leading to some standard renditions that we have now. I believe the Majority Chief Whip can attest to that fact. Myself, Hon Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi, Hon Alhaji Ben Abdallah Banda, Hon Shaibu Mahama and the former Member for Tamale, Hon Inusah Fuseini. Those are under the feet of—

Mr Dafeamekpor: And the former Chairman for Constitutional and Legal Affairs Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is Hon Banda.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Hon Banda.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, we have to do the same thing for—

Mr Dafeamekpor: And the great Hon Yileh Chireh.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the almighty Hon Yileh Chireh. We have to do the same thing for the Ninth Parliament. So, it is good you are expressing interest. You need not be a lawyer. Hon Kyei-Mensah-Bonsu was not a lawyer, but he had a special interest in this. So, please, develop your interest. I encourage you to take it up.

Hon Members, on this note, we have sat beyond five hours and been fortified by Standing Order 56, I will proceed to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 5.57 p.m. till Saturday, 12th July, 2025 at 10.00 o'clock in the forenoon.

